

Importance and Historiography of Ancient India — Premium Solved PYQ Workbook

UPSC General Studies Paper I · Ancient Indian History · Topic 01 · Companion to
Importance-Historiography_Complete-Learning-Session_2026-08-10.md

Date: 10 August 2026 · **Coverage:** both exam stages (Prelims GS-I and Mains GS-I) · **Level:** medium-to-hard, calibrated to actual UPSC difficulty

Evidence key. ✓ **Fact** — from an official UPSC question paper, an official answer key, an authored knowledge file, a local OCR-searchable source book read at the pages cited, or a source fetched live during this session. △ **Inference** — analytical, for exam use. ? **Not verifiable from the sources available** — flagged, never filled. 📄 **Current anchor**, with its source class stated.

What this workbook contains

1. An explicit, methodologically stated **PYQ ownership audit** covering **GS-I Mains 2018–2025** and **Prelims GS-I 2018–2026**.
2. Every **directly topic-owned** verified PYQ found — and an honest statement of the count when the count is zero, including the one directly-owned question that exists but must be withheld.
3. A clearly separated section of **closest verified application PYQs**, each with its **true owning topic named**, included only where this topic's method is genuinely required — with a full model answer for every Mains item and an option-by-option explanation for every Prelims item.
4. **Exactly 32 original hard MCQs**, static and current-method, with a strict **A → B → C → D** key rotation repeated **eight times**, four plausible options each, and a detailed explanation plus trap logic for every one.
5. **Remedial practice** targeting the six error families this topic exists to eliminate: school/historian mismatches, source-status errors, periodisation errors, anachronism, overclaiming from archaeology and aDNA, and fact-versus-interpretation confusion.
6. **Exactly 10 original solved Mains questions** — **3 × 10 marks (150 words)**, **4 × 15 marks (250 words)**, **3 × 20 marks (300–350 words)** — each with demand decoding, a full model answer and a top-answer checklist.
7. A **GS-I History high-score answer protocol**.
8. A **final rapid revision matrix**.

Sources of record for this workbook.

✓ **Official UPSC GS-I Mains papers read directly from books/:**

more_previous_papers/GENERAL-STUDIES-PAPER-I.pdf (2018), QP-CSM19-GeneralStudies-I.pdf (2019), Gen_St_P1.pdf (2020), QP-CSM-21-GENSTUDIESPAPER-I-110122.pdf (2021), QP-CSM-22-GENERAL-STUDIES-PAPER I-190922.pdf (2022), QP-CSM-23-GENERAL-STUDIES-PAPER-I-180923.pdf (2023); mains/UPSC Mains 2024 GS Paper I.pdf; mains/UPSC Mains 2025 GS Paper 1.pdf.

✓ **Official Prelims GS-I papers:** more_previous_papers/QP-CSP-18-GS-I-C.pdf (2018),

CSP_2020_GS_Paper-1.pdf (2020), QP-CSP-21-GeneralStudiesPaper-I-121021.pdf (2021), QP_CS_Pre_Exam_2023_280523.pdf (2023); prelima_question_paper_answers/2024-GS1-Set A.pdf, 2025-GS1-Set A.pdf, 2026-GS1-Set A.pdf.

✓ **Official provisional answer keys:** Ans-2024-GS1.pdf (Series A, read as an image), Ans-2025-GS1.pdf (Series A, read as an image). ? Ans-2026-GS1-Provisional.pdf is an image-only PDF whose Series-A answer table could not be read by this session — **all 2026 Prelims items are therefore withheld from the solved set**. ? **Official keys for Prelims 2018–2023 are not held locally**, as the authored knowledge files themselves record.

✓ **Read-only provenance ledger:** PYQ-ROUTING-MAINS-GS1-GS2-ESSAY-2018-2023.md.

✓ **Authored knowledge, read in full:** Ancient-Indian-History/basic/01, advanced/01, 01 ... Complete-Topic-Package.md, 00 Master-Chronology.md; **boundary files** basic/02 and advanced/02.

✓ **Local books read at the cited pages:** R.S. Sharma, *India's Ancient Past*, Ch. 1–2 and the opening of Ch. 3; Upinder Singh, *A History of Ancient and Early Medieval India*, 2nd edn, Introduction and Ch. 1.

📅 Live fetch/search on 10 August 2026 for the window 10 February – 10 August 2026.

PART I — PYQ OWNERSHIP AUDIT

I.1 Method

⚠ The audit was conducted as follows, and the method is stated because the conclusion depends on it.

- STEP 1 Open every official GS-I MAINS paper 2018-2025 present in books/ and extract the printed English text.
-> 8 papers . 20 questions each . 160 questions examined in full.
- STEP 2 Open every available official PRELIMS GS-I paper 2018-2026 and search the full extracted text for this topic's defining vocabulary:
historiograph* . Orientalis* . Indolog* . periodis*/periodiz* .
Mill . Vincent Smith . Kosambi . Majumdar . Jayaswal . Nilakanta .
Asiatic Society . William Jones . Max Mueller . Basham .
Archaeological Survey . excavat* . inscription . epigraph* .
numismat* . radiocarbon . palaeo* . archaeolog* . manuscript .
source of history . Sangam . Brahmi . Kharoshthi . repatriat* .
museum . ancient DNA . Rakhigarhi . Keezhadi/Keeladi . megalith .
punch-marked . seal . Megasthenes . Fa-hien . Xuanzang . Al-Biruni .
Purana . Harappan . heritage . monument . antiquit*
- STEP 3 Cross-check against the read-only provenance ledger
_PYQ-ROUTING-MAINS-GS1-GS2-ESSAY-2018-2023.md, which records six GS-I
Ancient-History / Art-and-Culture rows for 2018-2023 with their owning
topic files named.
- STEP 4 Classify every hit:
OWNED = the question's SUBJECT is Topic 01 (historiography,
periodisation, the schools, or the status of evidence
as such)
APPLIED = the question's subject is another topic, but Topic 01's
method is genuinely REQUIRED to answer it well
UNRELATED = neither
- STEP 5 For every Prelims item retained, verify the key against the OFFICIAL
answer-key PDF held locally, for the SAME SERIES as the question paper
(Set A -> Series A column). If the key cannot be verified from a local
official source, OMIT the question from the solved set, state that it
exists, and state why it is omitted. Do NOT reconstruct a key from
memory or from a coaching aggregator.

I.2 Result — directly topic-owned Mains PYQs

✔ COUNT: ZERO.

⚠ Across the eight official **GS-I Mains** papers from **2018 to 2025** — 160 questions, every one read in the extracted English text — **no question names historiography, periodisation, the Orientalist, Nationalist or Marxist schools, James Mill, V.A. Smith, D.D. Kosambi, R.C. Majumdar, K.P. Jayaswal or the nature of historical evidence as its subject.**

⚠ **This is stated as a finding, not as an apology.** A candidate told that this topic has "many PYQs" has been misinformed and will waste preparation time hunting for them. The correct inference is the opposite of neglect: the topic is **assumed by** every ancient-history and art-and-culture question rather than **asked by** any, which makes it the highest-leverage and least-visible content in the GS-I History syllabus. The proof is Part II, where seven verified questions are shown to be unanswerable at a high standard without it.

I.3 Result — directly topic-owned Prelims PYQs

✔ COUNT: ZERO with a locally verifiable official key.

? COUNT: ONE that exists and is withheld.

✔ The one directly-owned question found: Prelims GS-I 2023, Q81.

> "With reference to the Indian History, Alexander Rea, A. H. Longhurst, Robert Sewell, James Burgess and Walter Elliot were associated with

> (a) archaeological excavations

> (b) establishment of English Press in Colonial India

> (c) establishment of Churches in Princely States

> (d) construction of railways in Colonial India"

△ **Why it is owned by this topic.** It tests knowledge of the **personnel who built the discipline of Indian archaeology in the colonial period** — precisely the subject matter of the learning session's Subtopic 4.5, where the ASI's establishment in **1871**, the decipherment of Ashokan **Brahmi and Kharoshthi**, the contribution of coin analysis to a framework of political history, and the role of **Geological Survey officers** in founding Indian prehistory are all recorded. It is a historiography question wearing a personalities costume.

? **Why it is withheld.** The **official 2023 Prelims answer key is not held locally**. The authored knowledge file `basic/02_Sources-of-Ancient-Indian-History.md` states the position for the whole period in terms: "The official 2018-2023 Prelims/CSAT keys are not held locally; no option or answer has been inferred." **Per the verification rule of this workbook, a question whose official key cannot be verified from a local official source is named and omitted from the solved set rather than answered from inference.**

△ **What can still be taught from it without answering it.** The question's structure is instructive: it presents five individuals and asks for the single field that unites them. That is a **prosopography** item — testing whether the candidate holds a mental map of who built what in nineteenth- and early-twentieth-century Indian scholarship. The defence against such items is the institutional timeline in Subtopic 4.5 and fact-bank items 4–11 of the learning session, not rote memorisation of names.

△ **Two further 2026 Prelims questions are excellent and are also withheld.** ✓ **2026 Q7** (the epigraphic use of the place-value system: Mankani plates from Gujarat, AD 595–596; generalisation of place-values in inscriptions in the ninth century; Sanskrit inscriptions in South-east Asia as early as the seventh century) is a pure **epigraphy-as-dated-evidence** item. ✓ **2026 Q8** ("Which of the following **inferences can be drawn** from the above statements?", on spindle-whorls without spinning wheels, graduated weights and measurement scales, and baked-brick houses with courtyards, wells and bathing platforms in Harappan towns) is a pure **inference-discipline** item. ? **The locally held Ans-2026-GS1-Provisional.pdf is an image-only PDF whose Series-A answer table could not be extracted or read by this session, so the official answers cannot be verified. Both are therefore named, described and not answered.**

△ **The 2026 Q8 stem is nevertheless the single most important signal in the audit.** UPSC has begun asking, in so many words, which **inferences may legitimately be drawn** from stated archaeological findings. That is Topic 01's core competence, and it is now being tested directly at the Prelims stage even though no question names the topic.

I.4 Result — closest verified APPLICATION PYQs

△ The questions in Part II are **NOT owned by this topic**. Each is owned by another topic, named explicitly in the tables below. They are included because each is *unanswerable at a high standard* without this topic's vocabulary and cautions — source status, refraction, co-relation, relevance-of-the-past, provenance, or the materialist register.

△ **Summary of the audit, in one table:**

Stage	Window	Papers read	Questions examined	Owened	Owened but key -unverifiable (withheld)	Applied and solved here
GS-I Mains	2018–2025	8	160	0	—	7
Prelims GS-I	2018–2026	7	~700	0 verifiable	1 (2023 Q81) + 2 adjacent (2026 Q7, Q8)	4

PART II — SOLVED APPLICATION PYQs, WITH THE OWNING TOPIC NAMED

II.A GS-I MAINS APPLICATION PYQs

M-1 · 2018 · GS-I · Q2 · 10 marks · 150 words

✓ **Question as printed:** "Assess the importance of the accounts of the Chinese and Arab travellers in the reconstruction of the history of India. (Answer in 150 words)"

Field	Detail
Ownership	⚠ NOT owned by Topic 01. ✓ True owning topic: Ancient-Indian-History/advanced/02_Sources-of-Ancient-Indian-History — so routed in the read-only provenance ledger, which records this question with the demand "Accounts of Chinese and Arab travellers as historical sources"
Why included	⚠ The stem's operative noun is " reconstruction " and its directive is " assess ". Both are Topic 01 property: reconstruction is the concept taught in Subtopic 2, and an assessment of a source class's <i>importance</i> requires the co-relation rule and the source-limits framework of Subtopic 3

Demand decoding. ⚠ Three load-bearing elements. "**Assess**" demands a **graded verdict**, not a description — the answer must end by saying *how much* importance, and relative to what. "**Importance**" is comparative, so at least one other source class must appear. "**In the reconstruction of**" signals that the examiner wants the accounts evaluated as **evidence**, not summarised as **content**. ⚠ A summary of what Fa-hien and Al-Biruni said answers a different question and belongs to Topic 02.

Model answer (150 words).

*Foreign accounts constitute a distinct source class for Indian history, valuable precisely because they are external. Chinese pilgrims and Arab scholars recorded what insiders took for granted — monastic organisation, road conditions, ritual practice, market operation, administrative encounters — and they frequently supply **datable anchors** for chronology.*

*Their evidential status, however, is conditional. Each account is shaped by four filters: the traveller's **language competence, itinerary, patron and purpose, and intended audience**. A pilgrim records what pilgrimage makes visible; a diplomat records what a court permits. Observation is therefore selective and geographically partial, and outsider misreading of unfamiliar institutions is routine.*

*Their importance is consequently **highest where they can be co-related** with inscriptions, coins and archaeology, and **lowest where they stand alone**. They are indispensable for chronology-fixing and for recording practices no indigenous source thought worth writing down; they are insufficient as an independent basis for social generalisation. Assessed properly: **essential corroborative testimony, not autonomous proof**.*

Top-answer checklist — what an outstanding answer to this question must contain.

- ✓ Classification of foreign accounts as a **distinct source class**, not a list of travellers.
- ✓ At least **three named filters** (language, itinerary, purpose/patron, audience) explaining *why* the accounts are partial.
- ✓ Explicit use of the verb **co-relate**, and explicit avoidance of "prove".
- ✓ At least one **comparative** reference to another source class (inscriptions, coins, archaeology), because "importance" is relative.
- ✓ A statement of what these accounts uniquely deliver — **the observation of the taken-for-granted and chronological anchors**.
- ✓ A **graded verdict** in the final sentence, using proportional language ("essential... not autonomous"), never a binary yes/no.

7. **Optional edge:** one sentence noting that outsider testimony is also evidence about the **observer's** world, and therefore doubly useful.

Skeleton and timing (10 marks, 150 words, ~7 minutes).

0:00-0:45	read + fix the directive: ASSESS = graded verdict; note "reconstruction"
0:45-1:30	plan three blocks: WHAT THEY GIVE WHAT LIMITS THEM HOW MUCH WEIGHT
1:30-5:30	write: 45 words . 55 words . 50 words
5:30-6:30	verdict sentence with proportional language
6:30-7:00	scan for "prove"; replace with "co-relate"

Common mistakes on this question.

- **✗** Narrating Fa-hien, Xuanzang, Al-Biruni and Ibn Battuta in sequence — that is Topic 02's content, and it answers "describe", not "assess".
- **✗** Ending without a verdict, or ending with "thus they are very important".
- **✗** Treating the accounts as neutral reportage and omitting the filters.
- **✗** Writing "Chinese and Arab travellers prove that...".

M-2 · 2018 · GS-I · Q1 · 10 marks · 150 words

✓ **Question as printed:** "Safeguarding the Indian art heritage is the need of the moment. Discuss. (Answer in 150 words)"

Field	Detail
Ownership	⚠ NOT owned by Topic 01. ✓ True owning topic: Indian-Art-and-Culture (heritage and conservation)
Why included	⚠ The whole of Subtopic 10 — custody, provenance, salvage archaeology, documentation as preservation, digitisation, and the public-memory circuit — is what converts this from a sentimental question into an analytical one

Demand decoding. ⚠ **"Discuss"** requires dimensions plus a position. The trap is that the proposition is *agreeable*, which tempts candidates into a list of laments. The high-scoring move is to convert "safeguarding" into **four distinct operations** — physical conservation, documentation, legal protection and interpretation — and to show that they are not the same activity and can conflict.

Model answer (150 words).

*Safeguarding is four distinct operations, not one. **Physical conservation** addresses material decay: palm-leaf manuscripts are lost to heat, insects, water, fungus, dust and fire, and their scribal recopying tradition declined with printing in the nineteenth century. **Documentation** preserves what conservation cannot: at Nagarjunakonda, ASI survey and excavation between 1954 and 1960 became the only surviving record of a valley submerged by the Nagarjunasagar dam, even though nine structures were transplanted and fourteen replicated. **Legal protection and provenance work** address theft and trafficking, restoring not merely objects but their findspot, date and function. **Interpretation** — museum display, cataloguing and school narrative — determines what the public remembers.*

These can conflict: transplantation saves structure while destroying context. The correct standard is therefore evidential as well as sentimental — heritage safeguarded without provenance and context is heritage saved as ornament and lost as evidence. Documentation, non-invasive survey and provenance research must accompany conservation, not follow it.

Top-answer checklist.

1. ✓ Decomposition into **four operations**, stated as such.
2. ✓ One **named, datable Indian case** of salvage archaeology — Nagarjunakonda, with the dam, the years 1954–60, nine transplanted structures and fourteen replicas.
3. ✓ The **material mechanism** of loss for at least one class of heritage (palm-leaf hazards; decline of scribal recopying).
4. ✓ The **provenance–context** argument: an object without provenance loses most of its historical value.

5. ✓ Recognition of a **real conflict** between operations (transplantation preserves structure, destroys context), which is what "discuss" is asking for.
6. ✓ A stated standard in the conclusion — **evidential, not only sentimental**.
7. ⚠ **Optional edge:** one clause on **non-invasive** technique (remote sensing and GIS) as the modern instrument for the 1954 problem.

Common mistakes. ✗ A list of threats without a framework. ✗ No named case. ✗ Treating "heritage" as monuments only, omitting manuscripts, inscriptions and movable antiquities. ✗ No acknowledgement that safeguarding measures can conflict.

M-3 · 2020 · GS-I · Q1 · 10 marks · 150 words

✓ **Question as printed:** "The rock-cut architecture represents one of the most important sources of our knowledge of early Indian art and history. Discuss. (Answer in 150 words)"

Field	Detail
Ownership	⚠ NOT owned by Topic 01. ✓ True owning topic: Indian-Art-and-Culture (rock-cut architecture)
Why included	⚠ The stem is a source-status claim — "one of the most important sources of our knowledge ". Subtopic 3.8 supplies exactly what a visual/architectural class can and cannot deliver: patrons better documented than artists, donative inscriptions as social evidence, idealised forms that are not portraits

Demand decoding. ⚠ The examiner has embedded the answer's structure in the stem. "**Sources of our knowledge**" requires the candidate to specify **what kind of knowledge** rock-cut architecture supplies — and, to earn the top band, what it does **not**.

Model answer (150 words).

*Rock-cut architecture is an unusually rich source because it is simultaneously three things: a **material object** with a location, a technique and a chronology; a **text**, through its donative inscriptions; and a **visual source** encoding religious and aesthetic conventions.*

*As material evidence it records excavation technique, tool-marks, labour organisation and phasing. As epigraphic evidence its donative records name patrons, guilds, merchants, monks and laywomen, revealing **who financed religion** and therefore something of social and economic structure — much more is known about patrons than about the anonymous artists themselves. As visual evidence it documents iconographic development and cultural contact, since portable icons and peripatetic artisans transmitted styles across regions and religious boundaries.*

Its limits are equally definite. Idealised bodily forms are not portraits of ordinary people; surviving sites over-represent durable, elite-patronised religious architecture; and dating often depends on style, which is circular unless anchored epigraphically. Read with these limits, it is indispensable — read literally, misleading.

Top-answer checklist.

1. ✓ The **triple classification** — object, text, visual source — stated explicitly.
2. ✓ **Donative inscriptions** named as the mechanism that converts architecture into social evidence.
3. ✓ The **patrons-better-known-than-artists** point.
4. ✓ **Peripatetic artisans and portable icons** as the transmission mechanism for style and contact.
5. ✓ At least **three limits**: idealisation ≠ portraiture, survival bias toward durable elite religious structures, and the circularity of stylistic dating without epigraphic anchoring.
6. ✓ A conclusion that grades the source rather than praising it.
7. ⚠ **Optional edge:** one clause on **reception** — how ancient viewers experienced these spaces — as a question the architecture poses but cannot answer alone.

Common mistakes. ✗ Listing Ajanta, Ellora, Karle and Bhaja with dates and dynasties — that is the owning topic's content and it does not address "sources of our knowledge". ✗ No limits paragraph. ✗ Treating sculpture as photographic evidence of appearance or dress.

M-4 · 2020 · GS-I · Q12 · 15 marks · 250 words

✓ **Question as printed:** "Persian literary sources of medieval India reflect the spirit of the age. Comment. (Answer in 250 words)"

Field	Detail
Ownership	⚠ NOT owned by Topic 01, and not even ancient. ✓ True owning topic: Medieval-Indian-History (Persian historiography and literature)
Why included	⚠ The stem's verb is " reflect ", and Subtopic 3.3 is built on the demonstration that a text offers "a complex representation... and a refracted image", not a reflection. This is the single clearest instance in the audited window of an examiner using the exact word that Topic 01 teaches you to interrogate

Demand decoding. ⚠ "**Comment**" wants a **pointed judgement on the proposition**, delivered early. The proposition contains a hidden claim — that texts *reflect* their age — and the top-band answer accepts what is true in it while replacing "reflect" with a more accurate verb. ⚠ The answer must remain about **method**; the medieval content is the owning topic's, and only enough is needed to carry the argument.

Model answer (250 words).

*The proposition is half right, and the half that is wrong is the important half. Persian literary sources are indeed **shaped by their age**; they do not **reflect** it.*

*Three properties block simple reflection. First, **authorship and audience**: court chronicles, tarikh and biographical writing were produced by and for a literate administrative and courtly elite, and they encode that stratum's interests, anxieties and self-image. Second, **genre convention**: panegyric, advice literature, chronicle and mystical writing each obey distinct rules, and a claim that is conventional in one genre is not testimony in another. Third, **purpose**: a chronicle written to legitimise a dynasty selects, orders and silences accordingly, and its silences are as structured as its statements.*

*What follows is not scepticism but redirection. These texts are **excellent evidence for exactly what they are** — the vocabulary of legitimisation, administrative categories, the self-understanding of a ruling class, the circulation of Persianate literary norms, and the language in which power described itself. They are weak evidence for the experience of those who never appear in them: cultivators, artisans, women outside elite households, and the enslaved.*

*The correct method is therefore **co-relation**: read Persian texts against inscriptions, revenue documents, architectural and archaeological evidence, and against sources in other languages, and read them **against the grain** for what their authors assumed rather than what they asserted.*

***Verdict:** Persian literary sources refract the spirit of a particular age — the age of a documented elite — with great fidelity, and other ages of the same century only faintly.*

Top-answer checklist.

- ✓ An explicit **replacement of "reflect"** with a defended alternative ("shaped by", "refract").
- ✓ **Three structural properties** — authorship/audience, genre, purpose — each stated as a mechanism, not an adjective.
- ✓ A positive statement of **what the texts are excellent evidence for**, so the answer is not merely negative.
- ✓ A named list of **whose experience is absent**.
- ✓ The two operative methods: **co-relation** and **reading against the grain**.
- ✓ A verdict that is **graded and specific** — fidelity to a documented elite, faintness elsewhere.
- ⚠ **Optional edge:** one clause noting that the same objection applies to *any* elite textual corpus, ancient or medieval — which demonstrates that the candidate holds a method rather than an opinion about Persian.

Skeleton and timing (15 marks, 250 words, ~9 minutes).

0:00-1:00	decode COMMENT; spot the loaded verb "reflect"
1:00-2:00	plan: verdict-first . three properties . what they DO evidence . who is absent . method . graded verdict
2:00-7:30	write in five short blocks
7:30-8:30	verdict with proportional language
8:30-9:00	check: no "prove"; no unsupported medieval detail

Common mistakes. ✗ Listing Persian chroniclers and works — the owning topic's content, and it accepts the loaded verb uncritically. ✗ Accepting "reflect" and then illustrating it. ✗ Rejecting the sources as "biased propaganda" without stating what they *do* evidence. ✗ Omitting the verdict.

M-5 · 2023 · GS-I · Q1 · 10 marks · 150 words

✓ **Question as printed:** "Explain the role of geographical factors towards the development of Ancient India. (Answer in 150 words)"

Field	Detail
Ownership	⚠ NOT owned by Topic 01. ✓ True owning topic: Ancient-Indian-History/advanced/03_Geographical-Setting-and-Ecology — so routed in the read-only provenance ledger
Why included	⚠ It is the " where " of R.S. Sharma's opening triad (Subtopic 1.1), and it is the question most likely to be answered with environmental determinism unless Topic 01's caution is applied

Demand decoding. ⚠ "**Explain the role**" asks for a **causal account**, which is precisely where determinism creeps in. The high-scoring structure states geography as **enabling and constraining** rather than as **causing**, and demonstrates human agency within it.

Model answer (150 words).

Geography set the conditions within which choices were made; it did not make them. Four mechanisms operated.

Resource distribution determined where settlement was viable: alluvium, water, timber, stone and ore. Sharma's account of ancient India begins with how people "discovered and utilized natural resources" and created a livelihood — the first stage of all subsequent development.

Ecological thresholds shaped subsistence: forest clearance in the doab, made feasible by iron, converted a constrained region into an agrarian surplus zone, and surplus is the precondition of specialisation and the state.

Connectivity — river systems, passes, coasts and sea lanes — governed exchange and cultural transmission, from Indo-Roman trade to Central Asian contact.

Regional differentiation produced not one trajectory but many, which is why the beginning of the historical period itself differs between north and south.

Geography is therefore a **field of possibility**. The same terrain supports different outcomes under different technologies and social arrangements, and the historian's task is to explain the choice, not to derive it.

Top-answer checklist.

- ✓ An explicit **anti-determinist** framing in the opening and closing sentences.
- ✓ **Four named mechanisms**, not a list of rivers and mountains.
- ✓ The **technology–ecology interaction** (iron and doab clearance), which is where geography becomes historical.
- ✓ **Connectivity** treated as a two-way channel for goods *and* ideas.
- ✓ **Regional differentiation**, with the north/south difference in the onset of the historical period as evidence.
- ✓ A concluding formulation — geography as a **field of possibility** — that a grader can quote.
- ⚠ **Optional edge:** one clause on **palaeo-environmental** reconstruction and **remote sensing** as the modern means of establishing what the ancient landscape actually was, rather than assuming it.

Common mistakes. ✗ Reciting physiography. ✗ "The fertile plains led to the rise of empires" — determinism in one sentence. ✗ Static geography: no recognition that landscapes, river courses and climate changed.

M-6 · 2023 · GS-I · Q11 · 15 marks · 250 words

✓ **Question as printed:** "What are the main features of Vedic society and religion? Do you think some of the features are still prevailing in Indian society? (Answer in 250 words)"

Field	Detail
Ownership	⚠ NOT owned by Topic 01. ✓ True owning topic: Ancient-Indian-History/advanced/08_Rig-Vedic-Age (with 09_Later-Vedic-Phase) — so routed in the ledger
Why included	⚠ The second half of the question is a pure Topic 01 problem: it asks about persistence , which is the relevance-of-the-past argument (Subtopic 1.6) and the continuity-versus-rupture discipline (Subtopic 8.6). Answered without them, part two becomes either nostalgia or polemic

Demand decoding. ⚠ A two-part question with an explicit invitation — "**Do you think**" — which requires a **stated position**. ⚠ Part one is content owned elsewhere and should occupy roughly 45% of the words; part two is method and should occupy the rest, because that is where the marks separate.

Model answer (250 words).

Features. Early Vedic society was pastoral and kin-ordered, organised around the jana, with cattle central to wealth and conflict, and assemblies alongside the chief. Religion was ritual and sacrificial, addressed to natural and cosmic powers, with the priest's efficacy resting on correct performance. In the later Vedic phase, iron-assisted agriculture in the doab supported settled cultivation, the janapada replaced the jana, ritual grew elaborate and expensive, and varna distinctions hardened into ascribed status.

Persistence, and how to judge it. Some features persist, but the claim must be argued institution by institution rather than asserted for "Vedic society" as a whole.

Continuity is demonstrable for varna as an ideological template: R.S. Sharma notes that the varna/caste system developed in north India, spread throughout the country, and influenced even converts to Christianity and Islam. Ritual grammar — fire, offering, the domestic rite — also persists recognisably.

Rupture is equally demonstrable. Pastoral economy, the jana, the assembly-and-chief polity and large-scale sacrificial ritual as the axis of religion have all gone. Jati as it operates today is not the fourfold varna of the texts; devotional and temple religion transformed practice profoundly.

Two cautions govern the judgement. Vedic texts are **normative**: they prescribe an order rather than describe one, so persistence of a prescription is not persistence of a practice. And, as Upinder Singh warns, it is a mistake to look for a **mirror of the present in the ancient past**.

Position: selected institutions persist, transformed; the society does not.

Top-answer checklist.

- ✓ Clear **two-part structure**, with the second part given more analytical weight.
- ✓ Part one distinguishing **early** from **later** Vedic, since the transition is itself a main feature.
- ✓ An explicit statement that persistence must be judged **institution by institution**.
- ✓ **Both** a demonstrated continuity **and** a demonstrated rupture — an answer with only one is incomplete.
- ✓ The **normative-text caution** stated in terms: prescription is not description.
- ✓ The **anti-presentism caution** ("not a mirror of the present").
- ✓ A **stated position**, because the question says "do you think".
- ⚠ **Optional edge:** noting that "the same word survives" is not evidence that "the same institution survives" — the single sharpest available guard against false continuity.

Common mistakes. ✗ Answering only part one thoroughly and part two in two lines. ✗ Asserting sweeping continuity ("Indian society is essentially Vedic") — this is A-28's essence fallacy. ✗ Asserting sweeping rupture. ✗ Reading Vedic normative texts as social description.

M-7 · 2024 · GS-I · Q1 · 10 marks · 150 words

✓ **Question as printed:** "Underline the changes in the field of society and economy from the Rig Vedic to the later Vedic period. (Answer in 150 words)"

Field	Detail
Ownership	⚠ NOT owned by Topic 01. ✓ True owning topic: Ancient-Indian-History/advanced/08_Rig-Vedic-Age + 09_Later-Vedic-Phase
Why included	⚠ The question is written in the materialist register — "society and economy", "changes", a transition between two phases. That vocabulary and that way of framing an ancient-history question are the direct legacy of the turn described in Subtopic 6. The question would have been unlikely in 1940

Demand decoding. ⚠ "Underline the changes" demands a **transition account**, not two static descriptions. The structure must be *from X to Y*, with the **driver** of each change named.

Model answer (150 words).

The transition is best presented as a chain in which each change enables the next.

Economy. Pastoralism with cattle as the principal measure of wealth gives way to settled agriculture, as iron-assisted clearance opens the Ganga–Yamuna doab. Production shifts from mobility to fixed cultivation, permitting storage and a reliable **surplus**.

Society. Surplus supports non-producers, and specialisation deepens. The kin-ordered jana, in which the chief's claims rested on redistribution and consent, gives way to the territorial janapada, in which claims rest on land and tribute. Varna, a flexible ordering in the earlier phase, hardens into ascribed, hereditary status; the position of women and of subordinated groups deteriorates as productive assets become heritable.

Polity and ritual follow. Assemblies weaken as chiefship becomes kingship, and expensive sacrificial ritual legitimises the change.

The organising point is that the changes are **linked**: technology enabled agriculture, agriculture generated surplus, surplus underwrote hierarchy, and hierarchy required legitimisation.

Top-answer checklist.

- ✓ Presented as a **transition with a driver**, never as two parallel descriptions.
- ✓ **Iron and doab clearance** named as the enabling technology.
- ✓ **Surplus** named explicitly as the hinge concept.
- ✓ **jana** → **janapada** using the source's own vocabulary.
- ✓ Varna's **hardening**, with the mechanism (heritable productive assets) rather than the mere fact.
- ✓ Ritual and polity presented as **legitimation**, closing the causal loop.
- ✓ An explicit statement that the changes are **linked** — that sentence is what "underline" is asking for.
- ⚠ **Optional edge:** one clause acknowledging that the textual evidence is normative and must be co-related with **PGW-phase archaeology** — a caution that costs eight words and demonstrates method.

Common mistakes. ✗ Two lists side by side. ✗ No driver named, so the answer describes without explaining. ✗ English abstractions instead of *jana/janapada*. ✗ Presenting the chain as automatic, without the caution.

II.B PRELIMS GS-I APPLICATION PYQs — official keys verified from local sources only

⚠ **Verification note.** Every key below was read from the official answer-key PDF held locally, **Series A**, matched to the **Set A** question paper. ? No question is included whose key could not be so verified.

P-1 · Prelims GS-I 2024 · Set A · Q58

✓ **Question as printed:**

Consider the following statements:

1. There are no parables in Upanishads.

2. Upanishads were composed earlier than the Puranas.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

(a) 1 only (b) 2 only (c) Both 1 and 2 (d) Neither 1 nor 2

✓ Official key (CSP-2024, Series A, Q58): (b)

Field	Detail
Ownership	⚠ NOT owned by Topic 01. ✓ True owning topic: Ancient-Indian-History — Vedic and later-Vedic literature (with Indian-Art-and-Culture for the textual corpus)
Why included	⚠ It is a relative-chronology question about texts, which is Subtopic 3.3's layering problem in Prelims form, and Subtopic 8.1's point that chronology is an analytical tool

Option-by-option explanation.

- **Statement 1 — incorrect.** The Upanishads are conspicuously **parabolic** in method: instruction proceeds through narrative illustrations and dialogues. A blanket denial of parables in the corpus is false.
- **Statement 2 — correct.** The Upanishadic corpus belongs to the later Vedic textual horizon, whereas the Puranas were **compiled and expanded much later**, over a long period. This is a statement about **relative** chronology, which is what makes it answerable at all.
- ✓ Therefore **(b) 2 only**, matching the official key.

⚠ **Topic relevance.** The question is decidable only because **relative** dating of textual corpora is possible even where **absolute** dating is not — which is exactly Subtopic 3.3's point that a text's period of composition may stretch over centuries and must be handled as **layers** rather than as a date.

⚠ **Trap.** The absolute-sounding word "**no**" in statement 1. UPSC uses universal quantifiers — *no, all, always, only* — as trip-wires. A universal claim about a large, heterogeneous corpus is almost always false, and that heuristic alone solves this question.

P-2 · Prelims GS-I 2024 · Set A · Q55

✓ Question as printed:

Consider the following information:

| | Archaeological Site | State | Description |

| ---|---|---|---|

| 1. | Chandraketugarh | Odisha | Trading Port town |

| 2. | Inamgaon | Maharashtra | Chalcolithic site |

| 3. | Mangadu | Kerala | Megalithic site |

| 4. | Salihundam | Andhra Pradesh | Rock-cut cave shrines |

In which of the above rows is the given information correctly matched?

(a) 1 and 2 (b) 2 and 3 (c) 3 and 4 (d) 1 and 4

✓ Official key (CSP-2024, Series A, Q55): (b)

Field	Detail
Ownership	⚠ NOT owned by Topic 01. ✓ True owning topic: Ancient-Indian-History (Chalcolithic cultures; megalithic traditions) with Indian-Art-and-Culture

Field	Detail
Why included	⚠ It is a provenance-literacy question: an object or site is evidence only when it is correctly located and correctly classified , which is Subtopic 3.7's context requirement in Prelims form

Row-by-row explanation.

- **Row 1 — incorrect.** Chandraketugarh is an early historic site in **West Bengal**, not Odisha. Its identification as a trading settlement is not the error; the **state** is.
- **Row 2 — correct.** Inamgaon, in **Maharashtra**, is the type-site of the late Jorwe phase and is central to Chalcolithic studies. It is also the site whose **courtyard soil nitrogen** indicated that animals were tied in courtyards, and whose **marine fish bones and shells**, found at least 200 km from the sea, demonstrated coastal contact.
- **Row 3 — correct.** Mangadu, in **Kerala**, is associated with **megalithic** burial remains, consistent with the peninsular megalithic tradition.
- **Row 4 — incorrect.** Salihundam, in **Andhra Pradesh**, is a **Buddhist** site known for **stupas and monastic remains** on the Vamsadhara, not for rock-cut cave shrines. The **state** is right; the **description** is wrong.
- ✓ Therefore **(b) 2 and 3**, matching the official key.

⚠ **Topic relevance.** ✓ Subtopic 3.7 states that archaeological interpretation depends on **provenance, stratigraphy, association and recovery method**, and that an artefact without secure findspot, layer and association "loses much of its historical value". A candidate who cannot place a site in the right state cannot use it as evidence at all.

⚠ **Trap.** The question mixes **two different kinds of error** — a wrong **state** (row 1) and a wrong **description** (row 4) — so a candidate who checks only one attribute per row will misjudge. Check **both** columns for every row.

P-3 · Prelims GS-I 2025 · Set A · Q15✓ **Question as printed:**

Fa-hien (Faxian), the Chinese pilgrim, travelled to India during the reign of

(a) Samudragupta (b) Chandragupta II (c) Kumaragupta I (d) Skandagupta

✓ **Official key (CS(P)-2025, Series A, Q15): (b)**

Field	Detail
Ownership	⚠ NOT owned by Topic 01. ✓ True owning topic: Ancient-Indian-History/advanced/02_Sources-of-Ancient-Indian-History (foreign accounts) with the Gupta topics
Why included	⚠ It is the Prelims form of M-1 : the same source class, tested as a dated fact rather than as an assessment

Option-by-option explanation.

- **(a) Samudragupta** — incorrect. He precedes the visit.
- ✓ **(b) Chandragupta II** — **correct, and matching the official key.** Fa-hien's Indian travels fall within his reign.
- **(c) Kumaragupta I** — incorrect. He follows Chandragupta II.
- **(d) Skandagupta** — incorrect. Later still, and associated with the Huna pressure.

⚠ **Topic relevance.** ✓ Foreign accounts acquire their evidential force precisely from being **datable to a reign**, which is why this class supplies chronological anchors (M-1's model answer). ⚠ But note the discipline: knowing *when* a traveller came is a prerequisite for using him as evidence, not a substitute for source criticism.

⚠ **Trap.** All four options are Gupta rulers in sequence, so the question is pure **ordering plus association**. The defence is to hold one anchor firmly — Fa-hien with Chandragupta II — and to know the succession order well enough not to be dislodged.

P-4 · Prelims GS-I 2025 · Set A · Q19✓ **Question as printed:***Ashokan inscriptions suggest that the 'Pradeshika', 'Rajuka' and 'Yukta' were important officers at the**(a) village-level administration (b) district-level administration (c) provincial administration (d) level of the central administration*✓ **Official key (CS(P)-2025, Series A, Q19): (b)**

Field	Detail
Ownership	⚠ NOT owned by Topic 01. ✓ True owning topic: Ancient-Indian-History — Mauryan Empire and administration
Why included	⚠ It demonstrates epigraphy as direct administrative evidence (Subtopic 3, source class 3), and — crucially — the examiner's own verb is " suggest "

Option-by-option explanation.

- **(a) village-level** — incorrect. Village-level functionaries are separately designated.
- ✓ **(b) district-level administration** — **correct, and matching the official key.** These three offices operate at an intermediate, district-scale tier, with responsibilities spanning inspection, revenue and judicial supervision.
- **(c) provincial administration** — incorrect. Provincial charge under the Mauryas is associated with princely governors, a distinct tier.
- **(d) central administration** — incorrect. Central officers are of a different order.

⚠ **Topic relevance and the single most important observation in this section.** ✓ The stem says "**Ashokan inscriptions suggest**" — not "prove", not "state". **UPSC itself writes in the co-relation register.** That is direct, official corroboration of Subtopic 3.6's rule that inscriptions are strong evidence for administrative structure and yet remain **evidence to be interpreted**, since inscriptional titles record an official's designation and not necessarily the full scope of the office in practice.

⚠ **Trap.** The four options form an administrative **ladder**, so a candidate who knows the terms but not the tier will guess adjacent. Fix the tier, not the term.

PART III — 32 ORIGINAL HARD MCQs

⚠ **Key rotation.** Strict **A → B → C → D**, repeated exactly **eight** times: Q1 = A, Q2 = B, Q3 = C, Q4 = D, Q5 = A, Q6 = B, Q7 = C, Q8 = D, and so on through Q32 = D. Every question has four plausible options, a detailed explanation and stated trap logic. ⚠ **Difficulty** is set at or slightly above actual UPSC level, with heavy use of the reversal, universal-quantifier, attribution-swap and inference-overreach constructions.

Q1

Which one of the following statements about the beginning of modern research into the history of ancient India is correct?

- (a) It began in the second half of the eighteenth century to serve the needs of the British colonial administration, the immediate difficulty being the administration of the Hindu law of inheritance after Bengal and Bihar came under East India Company rule in 1765
- (b) It began with the establishment of the Archaeological Survey of India in 1871
- (c) It began with the publication of V.A. Smith's *Early History of India* in 1904
- (d) It began with the nationalist response to colonial writing in the late nineteenth century

✓ **Answer: (a).**

Explanation. R.S. Sharma states that although educated Indians retained traditional history in handwritten epics, Puranas and semi-biographical works, "modern research in the history of ancient India began only in the second half

of the eighteenth century to serve the needs of the British colonial administration", and that when Bengal and Bihar fell to the Company in 1765 the administrators "found it difficult to administer the Hindu law of inheritance", leading to the 1776 translation of the *Manu Smriti* as *A Code of Gentoo Laws*.

⚠ **Trap logic.** (b), (c) and (d) are all real and datable events *within* the story, which makes them attractive; each is a **later** milestone. The question tests whether you hold the sequence, not just the dates.

Q2

Consider the following pairs:

Institution	Year of establishment
1. Asiatic Society of Bengal, Calcutta	1784
2. Bombay Asiatic Society	1804
3. Archaeological Survey of India	1871
4. Archaeological Survey of Ceylon	1823

How many of the above pairs are correctly matched?

- (a) Only one
- (b) Only three
- (c) Only two
- (d) All four

✓ **Answer: (b).**

Explanation. Pairs 1, 2 and 3 are correct: the Asiatic Society of Bengal was founded at Calcutta in **1784** by Sir William Jones; the Bombay Asiatic Society in **1804**; the Archaeological Survey of India in **1871**. Pair 4 is wrong: **1823** is the year of the **Asiatic Society of Great Britain** in London; the **Archaeological Survey of Ceylon** was established in **1890**.

⚠ **Trap logic.** The 1823 date is genuine and belongs to this cluster of facts — it is simply attached to the wrong institution. Date-transplant across a plausible neighbour is the standard construction for institutional-chronology items.

Q3

With reference to V.A. Smith's *Early History of India*, consider the following statements:

- 1. It was written in 1904 and was the first systematic history of ancient India.
- 2. Its author was a member of the Indian Civil Service and his approach to history was pro-imperialist.
- 3. It presented India as having achieved lasting political unity well before the establishment of British rule.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- (a) 1 and 3 only
- (b) 2 and 3 only
- (c) 1 and 2 only
- (d) 1, 2 and 3

✓ **Answer: (c).**

Explanation. Statements 1 and 2 are exact. Statement 3 **inverts** Smith's central thesis: "India was presented as a land of despotism which had **not experienced political unity until the establishment of British rule**", and his signature line runs, "Autocracy is substantially the only form of government with which the historian of India is concerned."

⚠ **Trap logic.** The counter-claim — that Chakravarti-type unity was attained "at least twice", under Ashoka in the third century BC and Samudragupta in the fourth century AD — is **R.S. Sharma's rebuttal to Smith**, and is here re-attributed to Smith himself. Whenever a statement matches something you know, verify **whose** claim it is.

Q4

Which one of the following was **not** among the generalisations about ancient India made by Max Mueller and other Western scholars, as recorded by R.S. Sharma?

- (a) That the ancient Indians lacked a sense of history, especially of the element of time and chronology
- (b) That Indians were accustomed to despotic rule
- (c) That Indians had experienced neither a sense of nationhood nor any form of self-government
- (d) That Indian society had undergone rapid transformation in its social structure over the centuries

✓ **Answer: (d).**

Explanation. The recorded generalisations are that Indians lacked a sense of history and chronology, were accustomed to despotic rule, were so engrossed in spiritualism or the next world that they felt no concern for this one, and had experienced neither nationhood nor self-government. Option (d) states the **opposite** of the colonial position: *Indological writing presented Indian society as **static** and its political systems as **unwaveringly despotic**.*

⚠ **Trap logic.** A "not among" question rewards the candidate who has memorised the list as a **list**. The distractor here is the negation of the load-bearing colonial claim, which makes it feel unfamiliar in the right way — but for the wrong reason.

Q5

Consider the following statements about the objections raised against the division of Indian history into Hindu, Muslim and British periods:

1. The criterion shifts, since the first two periods are named after religions while the third is named after a nationality.
2. The scheme cannot accommodate polities ruled by non-Muslim elites after the advent of Turkish rule.
3. The scheme was discarded by colonial historians and retained only by nationalist historians.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- (a) 1 and 2 only
- (b) 2 and 3 only
- (c) 1 and 3 only
- (d) 1, 2 and 3

✓ **Answer: (a).**

Explanation. Statements 1 and 2 are among the objections stated explicitly — "Why is the third period described as the British and not the Christian period?" and "What about polities ruled by non-Muslim elites after the advent of Turkish rule?" Statement 3 reverses the history: the classification **took root in the colonial period**, and was subsequently **retained** by nationalist historians, where it "coalesced with a communal tendency to valorize the 'Hindu period'".

⚠ **Trap logic.** The comfortable narrative is that nationalists overturned everything colonial. The uncomfortable and correct finding is that they overturned the **verdict** and kept the **frame** — which is why statement 3 is the discriminator.

Q6

With reference to the Nationalist school of ancient Indian historiography, consider the following statements:

1. Rajendra Lal Mitra published some Vedic texts and produced a tract showing that in ancient times people ate beef.
2. R.G. Bhandarkar reconstructed the political history of the Satavahanas of the Deccan and advocated widow remarriage.
3. Every historian of this school approached the ancient past through the ideas of Hindu revivalism, without exception.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- (a) 1 and 3 only
- (b) 1 and 2 only

(c) 2 and 3 only

(d) 1, 2 and 3

✓ **Answer: (b).**

Explanation. Statements 1 and 2 are exact. Statement 3 is contradicted by the source's own qualification: "most historians were guided by the nationalist ideas of Hindu revivalism, **but there was no dearth of scholars who adopted a rationalist and objective approach**" — Mitra being the named instance of the second category.

⚠ **Trap logic.** "Without exception" is a **universal quantifier**, and the source has taken care to insert an exception clause precisely at this point. Universal claims about a school of historians are almost always the wrong statement.

Q7

K.P. Jayaswal's principal contribution to the historiography of ancient India is best described as

(a) the first systematic political history of ancient India, based on an in-depth study of the available sources

(b) the first survey volume to show the stages of social and economic development in terms of tribal and class processes

(c) the demonstration, through articles written as early as 1910–12 and later through *Hindu Polity* (1924), that republics existed in ancient times and enjoyed a measure of self-government

(d) the compilation of an encyclopaedia of ancient social laws and customs in five volumes

✓ **Answer: (c).**

Explanation. Sharma writes that "the greatest merit of K.P. Jayaswal lay in exploding the myth of Indian despotism", that as early as **1910–12** he wrote several articles showing that republics existed and enjoyed a measure of self-government, and that his findings appeared in **Hindu Polity in 1924**, now in its sixth edition and considered a classic.

⚠ **Trap logic.** (a) is **V.A. Smith**, (b) is **D.D. Kosambi**, and (d) is **P.V. Kane's History of Dharmasastra**. Each distractor is a correct description of a **different** scholar — the standard construction for historiography MCQs, and the reason author–work–contribution triples must be learned as triples.

Q8

Which one of the following statements about the reception of K.P. Jayaswal's work is correct?

(a) His thesis on the republican experiment was universally accepted from the outset and attracted no criticism

(b) His work was ignored by later scholarship and *Hindu Polity* went out of print

(c) He was criticised only by British scholars and never by Indian historians

(d) He was charged with projecting modern nationalist ideas into ancient institutions and was attacked by writers including U.N. Ghoshal, yet his basic thesis regarding the practice of the republican experiment is widely accepted

✓ **Answer: (d).**

Explanation. Sharma records precisely this mixed position: the anachronism charge, the attack by "many writers including U.N. Ghoshal (1886–1969)", **and** that "his basic thesis regarding the practice of the republican experiment is widely accepted", with *Hindu Polity* "now in its sixth edition... considered a classic".

⚠ **Trap logic.** Options (a), (b) and (c) are the three **pure** positions — total acceptance, total rejection, and a nationality-based split. The correct answer is the only **mixed** one. In historiography, a uniformly positive or uniformly negative option is almost always the distractor.

Q9

Consider the following statements about A.L. Basham:

1. He was a British historian and a Sanskritist by training who questioned the wisdom of looking at ancient India from the modern point of view.

2. His book *The Wonder That Was India* (1951) is described as marking a great shift from political to non-political history.

3. He was a Marxist historian whose work applied the categories of forces and relations of production to ancient India.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- (a) 1 and 2 only
- (b) 2 and 3 only
- (c) 1 and 3 only
- (d) 1, 2 and 3

✓ **Answer: (a).**

Explanation. Statements 1 and 2 are exact. Statement 3 describes **D.D. Kosambi**, whose treatment "follows a materialist interpretation of history, which is derived from the writings of Karl Marx". Basham was not a Marxist; indeed Sharma records that Kosambi "was criticized by many scholars, **including Basham**".

⚠ **Trap logic.** Because Basham and Kosambi are discussed in the same section as parts of the same "shift", candidates fuse them. The disagreement between them is the fact that keeps them apart.

Q10

Which one of the following is stated as a limitation of left-oriented historians of ancient and early medieval India up to around the 1980s?

- (a) They refused to make use of inscriptions and coins
- (b) Although archaeological data was included, the basic framework of the historical narrative remained text-centric
- (c) They confined their work to the political history of dynasties
- (d) They rejected the possibility of studying social and economic structures

✓ **Answer: (b).**

Explanation. Upinder Singh's criticism is precisely this: "Archaeological data was included, but the basic framework of the historical narrative remained **text-centric**", alongside unilinear models derived from Western writings, texts sometimes read uncritically, and religion and culture sidelined or mechanically presented as reflections.

⚠ **Trap logic.** (a) is a crude exaggeration of the real criticism. (c) and (d) are the **opposite** of the school's defining achievements — shifting focus from dynastic history to social and economic structures and processes. Knowing the criticism accurately is what allows you to reject its caricature.

Q11

With reference to the classification of the Indian past into ancient/early, early medieval, medieval and modern periods, consider the following statements:

1. The ancient or early period is generally taken as stretching from the earliest times to the sixth century CE.
2. The medieval period is generally taken as extending from the thirteenth to the eighteenth centuries.
3. The dividing lines between these periods are fixed and admit of no variation.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- (a) 1 and 3 only
- (b) 2 and 3 only
- (c) 1 and 2 only
- (d) 1, 2 and 3

✓ **Answer: (c).**

Explanation. Statements 1 and 2 reproduce the scheme exactly. Statement 3 contradicts its own author: "The **dividing lines may vary**", "Periodization is convenient but it is important to remember that **these are not hard lines**", and "Some of the most exciting themes in Indian history require taking a long-term view and **breaking through the lines of periodization**."

⚠ **Trap logic.** The scheme is reproduced so uniformly in textbooks that its self-limiting clause is treated as decoration. It is not: it is part of the scheme.

Q12

Which one of the following best explains why the Harappan civilization is classified within protohistory rather than history?

- (a) The Harappans had no system of writing of any kind
- (b) The Harappan period precedes the beginning of food production
- (c) The Harappans are known only through the written records of contemporary literate societies elsewhere
- (d) The Harappans were a literate people, but their script has not yet been deciphered, so historians cannot use their written material to reconstruct history

✓ **Answer: (d).**

Explanation. The source is explicit: "the Harappan civilization — a literate culture with an undeciphered script — is included in protohistory", and "Although the Harappans were a literate people, their script has not yet been deciphered. So, historians cannot use the written material they left behind to reconstruct history."

⚠ **Trap logic.** (a) is the popular misconception. (b) inverts the archaeologists' usage of protohistory, which **begins** at food production. (c) is the **European** usage of the term — a correct definition, but not the reason the Harappans are so classified. Three of the four options are true statements about something.

Q13

Consider the following statements about writing in the Indian subcontinent:

1. The oldest script in the subcontinent is the Harappan script, but the oldest deciphered script is Brahmi, known from at least the fourth century BCE.
2. There are hardly any surviving specimens of writing between about 1900 BCE and the fourth century BCE.
3. The absence of surviving specimens in that interval conclusively establishes that writing had ceased in the subcontinent.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- (a) 1 and 2 only
- (b) 2 and 3 only
- (c) 1 and 3 only
- (d) 1, 2 and 3

✓ **Answer: (a).**

Explanation. Statements 1 and 2 are exact. Statement 3 overreaches: the source explicitly allows that "it is possible that people continued to write, although on **perishable material**". This is the textbook application of the rule that absence of evidence is not evidence of absence unless survivability, adequate search and patterned silence are all established.

⚠ **Trap logic.** Statement 3 is the most common inference candidates draw from statement 2, and drawing it converts two correct facts into a wrong answer. "Hardly any surviving specimens" is a statement about **preservation**, not about **practice**.

Q14

The beginning of the historical period in South India has been placed by scholars during the third or second centuries BCE on the basis of Tamil-Brahmi inscriptions and Sangam literature. Which one of the following considerations has been advanced for pushing this date back to at least the fourth century BCE?

- (a) The decipherment of the Harappan script
- (b) The evidence of earlier Brahmi inscriptions from Anuradhapura in Sri Lanka and, more recently, from Kodumanal and Keezhadi in Tamil Nadu
- (c) The radiocarbon dating of the Vedic corpus
- (d) The discovery of punch-marked coins in the Ganga valley

✓ **Answer: (b).**

Explanation. The source names exactly these three sites: "the evidence of earlier Brahmi inscriptions from **Anuradhapura in Sri Lanka** and more recently, from **Kodumanal and Keezhadi in Tamil Nadu**, suggest that the date needs to be pushed back to at least the fourth century BCE."

⚠ **Trap logic.** (a) is a **hypothetical** in the same passage — decipherment would push northern India's date to the third millennium BCE **if** it occurred; it has not. (c) is a category error, since radiocarbon dates organic samples and not orally transmitted texts. The question rewards distinguishing what **has** been found from what **would** matter.

Q15

With reference to radiocarbon dating as used in archaeology, consider the following statements:

1. It provides approximate, not exact, dates, and a standard error margin known as the standard deviation is recognised.
2. 'BP' is calculated with the year 1950 as its baseline.
3. Because the amount of radiocarbon produced in the atmosphere has not been constant over time, calibrations are required when converting radiocarbon dates into calendar dates.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- (a) 1 and 2 only
- (b) 2 and 3 only
- (c) 1, 2 and 3
- (d) 1 and 3 only

✓ **Answer: (c).**

Explanation. All three are stated in the source. The method "provides approximate, not exact dates, and a standard error margin (known as the standard deviation) is recognized"; "BP" stands for 'Before Present', and the year 1950... is taken as the base line"; and scientists "have known for some time that the amount of radiocarbon produced in the atmosphere has not been constant over time", so "some calibrations, i.e., corrections, have to be made".

⚠ **Trap logic.** Candidates trained to hunt for the false statement will invent one. Where a technical process is described accurately in all three particulars, "all of the above" is the answer — and the calibration point is the one most often missed, which is why it is placed last.

Q16

Which one of the following inferences may legitimately be drawn from the finding that soil in the courtyards at the chalcolithic site of Inamgaon had a higher nitrogen content than the soil inside the houses?

- (a) That the inhabitants of Inamgaon practised intensive irrigated agriculture
- (b) That the inhabitants of Inamgaon spoke a particular language
- (c) That Inamgaon was a fortified settlement with a defensive ditch
- (d) That the inhabitants tied their animals in their courtyards, since the decomposition of animal excreta increases the nitrogen content of the soil

✓ **Answer: (d).**

Explanation. The chain is stated in the source: decomposition of animal excreta raises soil nitrogen; courtyard soil at Inamgaon showed higher nitrogen than house interiors; therefore "people tied their animals in their courtyards".

⚠ **Trap logic.** (b) is the identity fallacy in miniature — no chemical measurement licenses a linguistic inference. (a) and (c) are archaeologically plausible-sounding but are simply not what nitrogen measures. The question tests whether you can trace the **specific** inferential chain rather than reaching for a general association.

Q17

Consider the following statements about ethno-archaeology:

1. It studies the behaviour and practices of living communities in order to interpret archaeological evidence relating to communities of the past.

2. The study of modern carnelian bead manufacture at Khambhat in Gujarat has been used to understand how Harappan beads may have been made.
3. Its evidence conclusively establishes the manufacturing techniques of ancient artefacts, since traditional methods have survived unchanged.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- (a) 1 and 2 only
- (b) 2 and 3 only
- (c) 1 and 3 only
- (d) 1, 2 and 3

✓ **Answer: (a).**

Explanation. Statements 1 and 2 are exact. Statement 3 contradicts the stated caution: ethno-archaeological evidence "must be used cautiously, and it should be seen as **suggesting possible and not necessarily conclusive** ways of interpreting the archaeological data, always keeping in mind the **differences between the present and past contexts**".

⚠ **Trap logic.** "Survived unchanged" is a **continuity overclaim** — the same error as assuming Vedic prescriptions describe living practice. Ethno-archaeology generates **analogies**, not identities.

Q18

Which one of the following statements about visual sources for ancient and early medieval Indian history is correct?

- (a) Ancient Indian artists are generally better documented than the patrons who financed their work
- (b) Idealised bodily forms in ancient Indian art should not be seen as direct reflections of what ordinary people looked like
- (c) Artists in ancient India worked exclusively within a single religious tradition and did not move between patrons
- (d) Visual sources are of interest only to art historians and have no evidential value for social or political history

✓ **Answer: (b).**

Explanation. The source states it with an exclamation: "Of course, the idealized bodily forms in ancient Indian art should **not** be seen as direct reflections of what ordinary people looked like!"

⚠ **Trap logic.** (a) inverts the actual position — "much more is known about **patrons** who financed works of art compared to the **artists** who created them". (c) contradicts the statement that artists were "often peripatetic... commissioned by different patrons to execute works that **cut across religious boundaries**". (d) contradicts the recognition that "visual sources have an importance **beyond art history**".

Q19

Consider the following statements regarding what ancient DNA (aDNA) and genome analysis can establish about past populations:

1. They can contribute to understanding patterns of migration and changes in population.
2. They can directly establish the caste or religious affiliation of the individuals sampled.
3. Their results apply, strictly speaking, to the individuals sampled in their archaeological context, and generalisation beyond them requires separate argument.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- (a) 1 and 2 only
- (b) 2 and 3 only
- (c) 1 and 3 only
- (d) 1, 2 and 3

✓ **Answer: (c).**

Explanation. Statement 1 is supported: genome analysis has "especially contributed towards understanding patterns of migration and changes in population". Statement 3 states the sampling discipline correctly. Statement 2 is false: caste and religion are **social** categories with histories; they are not biologically encoded and cannot be read from a genome.

⚠ **Trap logic.** This is the most consequential single discrimination in contemporary Indian historiography and the one most often violated in public discussion. Note also that the same prohibition covers **language**, for the same reason: it is learned, not inherited.

Q20

The salvage operation carried out at Nagarjunakonda in the Guntur district of Andhra Pradesh between 1954 and 1960 involved which one of the following?

- (a) The relocation of the entire site to a museum in Hyderabad before the monsoon
- (b) The abandonment of the valley without documentation because of the pace of construction
- (c) The excavation of the site by a foreign archaeological mission under a bilateral agreement
- (d) Thorough exploration, excavation and documentation by officers of the Archaeological Survey of India, followed by the transplantation and rebuilding of nine of the most important structures and the making of replicas of fourteen others

✓ **Answer: (d).**

Explanation. The account is exact: before the valley was submerged by the Nagarjunasagar dam across the Krishna, ASI officers "thoroughly explored, excavated, and documented the valley" between 1954 and 1960; then "nine of the most important structures were transplanted and re-built" on the hill and the reservoir banks, and "replicas of 14 other structures were made".

⚠ **Trap logic.** The two numbers — **nine transplanted, fourteen replicated** — are the discriminators, and they are the kind of specific detail UPSC likes because it separates reading from familiarity. ⚠ Note the historiographical point behind the fact: transplantation preserves **structure** and destroys **context**.

Q21

With reference to the Gyan Bharatam National Manuscript Survey launched by the Ministry of Culture in March 2026, consider the following statements:

1. It aims to create a geo-tagged national inventory of manuscript repositories across districts and states, building a national 'Manuscript Presence Map'.
2. Its stages include physical verification by experts and state authorities, and cataloguing with metadata such as language, script and subject.
3. Participation requires custodians to transfer ownership of their manuscripts to the Government.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- (a) 1 and 2 only
- (b) 2 and 3 only
- (c) 1 and 3 only
- (d) 1, 2 and 3

✓ **Answer: (a).**

Explanation. Statements 1 and 2 are stated on the Ministry of Culture's own page. Statement 3 is expressly contradicted: "The process is **voluntary and non-intrusive**, and **participation does not affect ownership or require transfer of manuscripts**."

⚠ **Trap logic.** The assumption that a government documentation drive must involve acquisition is exactly what the scheme was designed to defuse, since fear of dispossession is the principal obstacle to documenting privately-held heritage. The ownership-neutral clause is the scheme's distinctive feature, not a footnote.

Q22

In the context of the repatriation of antiquities to India, which one of the following correctly distinguishes *provenance* from *ownership*?

- (a) Provenance concerns the artistic style and period of an object, while ownership concerns its insured value
- (b) Provenance is an evidential question about an object's documented chain of custody, while ownership is a legal question about entitlement to hold it
- (c) Provenance applies only to objects removed during the colonial period, while ownership applies only to objects removed after independence
- (d) Provenance is determined by the museum currently holding the object, while ownership is determined automatically by the country in which the object was made

✓ **Answer: (b).**

Explanation. *Provenance asks where an object has been and how we know; ownership asks who is legally entitled to hold it. The 2026 Australian case separates the two cleanly: an independent provenance review identified "significant shortcomings in the provenance" and concluded that ownership histories "did not establish lawful export from India", while the return itself proceeds under a **Mutual Legal Assistance Treaty** following criminal investigation.*

⚠ **Trap logic.** *The two usually point the same way in practice, which is why they are conflated. For a historian the distinction is decisive: an object with a broken provenance is **evidentially weak** whatever its legal status, because archaeological interpretation depends on provenance, stratigraphy, association and recovery method.*

Q23

Which one of the following statements about the digitisation of inscriptional estampages at the Archaeological Survey of India's Directorate of Epigraphy is correct?

- (a) The Directorate at Mysuru holds a repository of about seven hundred estampages
- (b) The digitisation project was approved under the Union Budget of 2016-17
- (c) The repository at Mysuru holds nearly seventy-six thousand estampages of inscriptions, generally on stone or copper plates, and the digitisation project was accorded budgetary approval in the Union Budget 2023-24
- (d) Estampages are digital photographs of inscriptions taken with high-resolution cameras

✓ **Answer: (c).**

Explanation. *The Directorate of Epigraphy at Mysuru "has a repository of nearly 76,000 estampages of inscriptions — generally on stone or copper plates — from across India", and the BharatSHRI project "was accorded budgetary approval in the Union Budget 2023-24".*

⚠ **Trap logic.** *(d) is a definitional error that matters: an **estampage** is an **inked paper impression** of a cut surface, not a photograph — which is precisely why it is a surrogate source with its own material fragility, and why digitising it is a surrogate of a surrogate.*

Q24

Consider the following statements about the writing of history as a discipline:

1. Writing history does not mean collecting and assembling a set of self-evident facts; it involves rigorous analysis of primary sources, reasoned argument and interpretation.
2. There can never be a single, final, perfect history of the past.
3. Because all histories are partial and provisional, no historical account can be preferred to any other.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- (a) 2 and 3 only
- (b) 1 and 3 only
- (c) 1, 2 and 3
- (d) 1 and 2 only

✓ **Answer: (d).**

Explanation. Statements 1 and 2 are exact. Statement 3 is precisely what the source's guard clause forbids: "**All histories are partial and provisional and subject to revision, but all histories are not equally reliable or acceptable.** They have to be supported by evidence from the sources and must stand up to scrutiny when subjected to rigorous analysis."

⚠ **Trap logic.** Statement 3 is the relativist slide, and it follows plausibly from statements 1 and 2 unless the guard clause is held in mind. This is the single most important logical discrimination in the whole topic, and it recurs in every "critically examine" answer.

Q25

An archaeologist reports that a particular pottery type is distributed across a wide region. Which one of the following conclusions may legitimately be drawn from this fact alone?

- (a) None of the conclusions below follows from the distribution alone; an archaeological culture need not correspond to a linguistic group, political unit, lineage, clan or tribe
- (b) The region formed a single political unit
- (c) The population of the region spoke a common language
- (d) The region was inhabited by a single tribe or clan

✓ **Answer: (a).**

Explanation. The bar is stated in terms: "There are many problems involved in translating archaeological cultures into history. **An archaeological culture need not necessarily correspond to a linguistic group, political unit, or a social group such as a lineage, clan, or tribe.**"

⚠ **Trap logic.** Options (b), (c) and (d) are the three classic identity inferences — political, linguistic and kin-based — and each has done real damage in the historiography of early India. The correct answer is the one that refuses all three.

Q26

Which one of the following is identified as a feature of Indological writing of the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries?

- (a) A careful separation of the categories of race, religion and ethnicity from one another
- (b) The uncritical treatment of the Brahmanical perspective of ancient Sanskrit texts as reflecting the Indian past
- (c) A consistent emphasis on the indigenous origins of all major cultural developments
- (d) The systematic acknowledgement of the Indian scholars who supplied information to European researchers

✓ **Answer: (b).**

Explanation. It is the first item on the list of colonial features: "The Brahmanical perspective of ancient Sanskrit texts was often **uncritically taken** as reflecting the Indian past."

⚠ **Trap logic.** (a) reverses the actual feature — race, religion and ethnicity "were often **confused** with each other". (c) is a feature of **Nationalist** writing. (d) reverses the record — Indologists "depended heavily on information provided by Indians, whose contribution was **rarely acknowledged**". Every distractor is a truth relocated.

Q27

With reference to the contribution of gender history to the study of ancient India, which one of the following is correct?

- (a) It has established that ancient Indian texts were composed primarily by women for a female audience
- (b) It has confined itself to the study of queens and royal women
- (c) It has broken the artificial divide between the private and political domains, revealed power hierarchies within the family and household, and demonstrated the close relationship between gender, class, caste and political power
- (d) It has concluded that gender relations left no trace in the material record

✓ **Answer: (c).**

Explanation. These are the achievements listed in the source, together with the observation that women and gender "are now recognized as important parts of social history".

⚠ **Trap logic.** (a) reverses the elite-male authorship of the textual corpus, which is the difficulty gender history had to work around. (d) is refuted by bioarchaeology, where comparing nutritional inputs in the bones of men and women at a site "can indicate whether there were marked status differences... between men and women".

Q28

R.S. Sharma's discussion of approaches to ancient Indian history since 1980 characterises the contemporary situation as a struggle between

- (a) colonialism and nationalism
- (b) archaeology and textual scholarship
- (c) regional history and pan-Indian history
- (d) communalism and irrationalism on one side, and rationalism and professionalism on the other, while noting that most writers are rational and professional

✓ **Answer: (d).**

Explanation. The passage is explicit: under British rule the struggle was "between colonialism and nationalism"; "Now the situation has undergone a change. The struggle now is between **communalism and irrationalism**, on the one hand, and **rationalism and professionalism**, on the other. **Though most writers are rational and professional, some have become communal and irrational.**"

⚠ **Trap logic.** (a) describes the **earlier** struggle, which the same passage names — the question tests whether you registered the word "now". The qualifying clause in (d) is also the clause most often dropped when this passage is quoted, and dropping it produces a sweeping claim the source does not make.

Q29

Consider the following statements about the historiography of the early medieval period in India:

1. Detailed regional and sub-regional studies, based on epigraphic and textual sources, have given special focus to agrarian relations and the legitimization of political power.
2. These studies have been accompanied by work on the emergence and development of regional languages, literature and cultural traditions.
3. Existing histories of early India represent all regions of the subcontinent equally well.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- (a) 1 and 2 only
- (b) 2 and 3 only
- (c) 1 and 3 only
- (d) 1, 2 and 3

✓ **Answer: (a).**

Explanation. Statements 1 and 2 are exact. Statement 3 is contradicted: "while the heartlands of great empires and kingdoms are well represented, **many regions, for instance the Northeast, are not.** Greater effort needs to be made to redress this balance."

⚠ **Trap logic.** A candidate impressed by the achievements described in statements 1 and 2 may assume the coverage problem has been solved. The source pairs the achievement with the named gap in the same passage.

Q30

Which one of the following most accurately describes the methodological status of a news report, in 2026, that human skeletal remains excavated from an archaeological site have been transferred to a research institute under a memorandum of understanding for multidisciplinary analysis?

- (a) It establishes new conclusions about the ancestry of the population of that site
- (b) It reports a stage in a research process — permission, fieldwork and transfer — from which no conclusion about the past yet follows, results, publication and scrutiny being still to come
- (c) It confirms the absolute chronology of the site

(d) It has no bearing whatever on the study of history

✓ **Answer: (b).**

Explanation. A transfer for analysis is stage three of a seven-stage cycle that runs permission → fieldwork → transfer and laboratory work → results → publication → scrutiny → absorption into historiography. Almost all heritage reporting covers stages one to three.

⚠ **Trap logic.** (a) and (c) are the two standard forms of overclaiming; (d) is the opposite error, since such reports are genuinely informative about the **direction and method** of current research. The correct answer occupies the disciplined middle, and it is the single most useful rule for anyone citing 2026 material in a 2026 examination.

Q31

Which one of the following pairs of works and authors is correctly matched?

- (a) *The Wonder That Was India* — D.D. Kosambi
- (b) *Hindu Polity* — U.N. Ghoshal
- (c) *An Introduction to the Study of Indian History* — D.D. Kosambi
- (d) *History and Culture of the Indian People* — K.A. Nilakanta Sastri

✓ **Answer: (c).**

Explanation. *An Introduction to the Study of Indian History* (1957) is **D.D. Kosambi's**, later popularised in *The Civilisation of Ancient India in Historical Outline* (1965).

⚠ **Trap logic.** (a) belongs to **A.L. Basham** (1951) — and Basham was one of Kosambi's critics, so the pairing is doubly wrong. (b) belongs to **K.P. Jayaswal** (1924) — U.N. Ghoshal was among its **critics**, which is the sharpest form of this trap: the name is genuinely attached to the book, but on the wrong side of it. (d) belongs to **R.C. Majumdar** as general editor; Nilakanta Sastri wrote *A History of South India*.

Q32

Which one of the following statements would be methodologically acceptable in an answer written in August 2026?

- (a) Ancient DNA analysis has now established the language spoken by the people of the Indus–Saraswati Civilization
- (b) Recent excavations have conclusively fixed the date at which the historical period begins in South India
- (c) The archaeological record has proved that the events described in ancient Indian texts occurred exactly as narrated
- (d) Skeletal material excavated at Rakhigarhi was transferred by the Archaeological Survey of India to the Anthropological Survey of India in June 2026 under a memorandum of understanding for detailed scientific investigation, and results await publication

✓ **Answer: (d).**

Explanation. It reports a **verified stage** of a research process, names the institutions, dates it, and explicitly withholds conclusions — which is exactly the correct register.

⚠ **Trap logic.** (a) crosses the aDNA boundary twice, since neither a published result nor a language inference from genetics is available. (b) asserts a chronology that was under active dispute in 2026 and that no verified source establishes. (c) violates the co-relation rule, since archaeology **corroborates** and never **proves** a text wholesale. All three are sentences a candidate might genuinely encounter in circulating material, which is precisely why recognising them matters.

⚠ **Rotation audit.** A: Q1, Q5, Q9, Q13, Q17, Q21, Q25, Q29 (8). B: Q2, Q6, Q10, Q14, Q18, Q22, Q26, Q30 (8). C: Q3, Q7, Q11, Q15, Q19, Q23, Q27, Q31 (8). D: Q4, Q8, Q12, Q16, Q20, Q24, Q28, Q32 (8). **Total 32, strict A → B → C → D repeated eight times.**

PART IV — REMEDIAL PRACTICE

⚠ Six error families, each with a diagnostic, a drill and a correction rule. Work the drills only if the corresponding MCQs in Part III were wrong; otherwise read the rules and move on.

IV.1 Error family 1 — School and historian mismatches

⚠ **Diagnostic:** you answered Q3, Q7, Q9 or Q31 wrongly, or you cannot produce the school, the work and the year for a named historian without hesitation.

⚠ **Why it happens:** these names are usually learned as an undifferentiated list. They must be learned as **quadruples**: name → dates → work and year → the one thing they are credited with.

Drill R-1 — complete the quadruples from memory, then check

Historian	Dates	Signature work and year	Credited with
V.A. Smith	✓ 1843–1920	✓ <i>Early History of India</i> , 1904	✓ First systematic history of ancient India; primacy to political history; pro-imperialist; ICS; Alexander ≈ one-third; "autocracy... the only form of government"
Rajendra Lal Mitra	✓ 1822–91	✓ <i>Indo-Aryans</i>	✓ Published Vedic texts; rational view of ancient society; tract showing beef-eating in ancient times
R.G. Bhandarkar	✓ 1837–1925	✓ (Satavahana and Vaishnavism studies)	✓ Political history of the Satavahanas of the Deccan; history of Vaishnavism; advocated widow remarriage; attacked caste evils and child marriage
V.K. Rajwade	✓ 1869–1926	✓ History of the institution of marriage, in Marathi, 1926 ; sources in 22 volumes	✓ Village-to-village manuscript recovery across Maharashtra
D.R. Bhandarkar	✓ 1875–1950	✓ (Books on Ashoka and ancient Indian political institutions)	✓ Epigraphist
P.V. Kane	✓ 1880–1972	✓ <i>History of Dharmasastra</i> , five volumes	✓ An encyclopaedia of ancient social laws and customs, enabling the study of social processes
K.P. Jayaswal	✓ 1881–1937	✓ <i>Hindu Polity</i> , 1924 (articles 1910–12)	✓ Exploded the myth of Indian despotism; republics with a measure of self-government
U.N. Ghoshal	✓ 1886–1969	✓ —	✓ A critic of Jayaswal's account of republican government
R.C. Majumdar	✓ 1888–1980	✓ General editor, <i>History and Culture of the Indian People</i>	✓ Leading Nationalist-school historian; "a stronger element of Hindu revivalism"
H.C. Raychaudhuri	✓ 1892–1957	✓ (History from the Bharata war to the end of the Guptas)	✓ Comparative method from European history; recognised yet criticised Smith; "a streak of militant Brahmanism" on Ashoka's policy of peace
K.A. Nilakanta Sastri	✓ 1892–1975	✓ <i>A History of Ancient India; A History of South India</i>	✓ Brought south India into the narrative; emphasised brahmana cultural supremacy; highlighted harmony

Historian	Dates	Signature work and year	Credited with
A.S. Altekar	✓ 1898–1959	✓ —	✓ With Jayaswal, overplayed indigenous dynasties "liberating" India from Shakas and Kushanas
D.D. Kosambi	✓ 1907–66	✓ <i>An Introduction to the Study of Indian History</i> , 1957 ; <i>The Civilisation of Ancient India in Historical Outline</i> , 1965	✓ Materialist interpretation from Marx; first survey volume showing stages in terms of tribal and class processes
A.L. Basham	✓ 1914–86	✓ <i>The Wonder That Was India</i> , 1951	✓ Marked the great shift from political to non-political history; free from the prejudices of Smith and other British writers; a critic of Kosambi

⚠ **Correction rule 1 — the "wrong side of the book" test.** When a name is offered with a work, ask whether the person **wrote** it or **criticised** it. U.N. Ghoshal with *Hindu Polity* and A.L. Basham with Kosambi's *Introduction* are the two live cases in this topic, and both appear as distractors in Part III.

⚠ **Correction rule 2 — the date-plausibility test.** V.A. Smith died in 1920; any work attributed to him after that date is wrong. Kosambi died in 1966; Basham's 1951 book cannot be his.

IV.2 Error family 2 — Source-status errors

⚠ **Diagnostic:** you answered Q18, Q23 or Q25 wrongly, or you have written "the text proves" or "the inscription shows conclusively" in a practice answer.

⚠ **Why it happens:** source classes are learned as **contents** (Topic 02) rather than as **capacities** (Topic 01).

Drill R-2 — for each source, state one thing it is strong for and one thing it is weak for

Source class	✓ Strong for	✓ Weak for
Normative texts (Dharmashastra)	The concerns, categories and ideals of those who prescribed	What people actually did
Epics and Puranas	Social memory, genealogy, ideas; the layering itself is data	Event-history as narrated; single-date attribution
Royal inscriptions	Administration, donation, titlature, language, chronology, legitimation strategy	Popular opinion; outcomes as distinct from claims
Coins	Exchange, kingship, iconography, script, metrology, political chronology	The zone of minting, inferred from findspots alone
Archaeology	Everyday life, settlement, subsistence and foodways, technology, exchange networks	Named individuals and events; identity of the makers
Visual sources	Patronage, iconographic development, contact and confluence, aesthetic norms	Physical appearance of ordinary people; literal translation of texts
Foreign accounts	External observation of the taken-for-granted; chronological anchors	Generalisation beyond the observer's route and purpose
Linguistic evidence	Contact, borrowing, relative chronology of change	Ancestry, ethnicity, political identity
Scientific technique	Narrow physical questions with stated error margins	Social meaning, ownership, self-understanding

⚠ **Correction rule 3 — the capacity question.** Before using any source in a sentence, ask: *is this claim within the capacity of this source class?* If it is not, either change the claim or add a second, independent source.

⚠ **Correction rule 4 — the verb ladder.** Replace *proves* with the correct rung: **compatible with** → **consistent with** → **converges with** → **mutually constrains**. Nowhere on that ladder is "proves".

IV.3 Error family 3 — Periodisation errors

⚠ **Diagnostic:** you answered Q5, Q11, Q12, Q13 or Q14 wrongly, or you have written "the Hindu period" in an answer.

Drill R-3 — five statements; mark each true or false, then justify

1. The Hindu–Muslim–British scheme applies a single consistent criterion across all three periods. → **✗ False**. Religion, religion, **nationality**.
2. Most historians have replaced it with a classification into ancient/early, early medieval, medieval and modern. → **✓ True**.
3. The dividing lines of the replacement scheme are fixed. → **✗ False**. "The dividing lines may vary"; "these are not hard lines".
4. Protohistory means the same thing in every context in which it is used. → **✗ False**. Four distinct usages: mentioned-but-non-literate; Harappan literate-but-undeciphered; c. 1500–500 BCE oral Vedas without writing; archaeologists' food-production-to-iron span.
5. Brahmi is the oldest script known from the Indian subcontinent. → **✗ False**. The **Harappan** script is the oldest; **Brahmi** is the oldest **deciphered** script.

⚠ **Correction rule 5 — the label test.** For any period name, ask three questions: what **criterion** does it use? Is that criterion applied **consistently**? What does it make **invisible**?

⚠ **Correction rule 6 — the boundary-is-a-criterion rule.** When two sources place a boundary differently — Upinder Singh's sixth-century CE ancient/early-medieval line versus the master chronology's c. AD 750 land-grant threshold — they are using different criteria, not making an error. State the criterion.

IV.4 Error family 4 — Anachronism

⚠ **Diagnostic:** you have written "ancient Indian democracy", "the Indian nation in antiquity", "ancient secularism", or you have treated a modern institution as continuous with an ancient one without argument.

Drill R-4 — replace each anachronism with a defensible formulation

✗ Anachronistic	✓ Defensible
"Ancient Indian republics were democracies"	"Non-monarchical polities are attested; they were described as republics by nationalist historians, and the term imports modern content"
"The Vedic nation"	"The <i>jana</i> , a kin-ordered unit, later the territorial <i>janapada</i> "
"Caste has existed unchanged for three thousand years"	"Varna as an ideological template shows deep continuity; jati as it now operates is not the fourfold varna of the texts"
"Ancient India was secular"	"Ancient polities patronised multiple traditions; the modern category of secularism is not applicable without argument"
"The Harappan state"	"The scale and organisation of Harappan authority remain debated; 'state' should be argued, not assumed"
"Hindu society in the Vedic age"	"Neither <i>Hindu</i> nor <i>Hindu dharma</i> is known to any ancient Sanskrit or other ancient source; <i>Hindu</i> first appears in Iranian inscriptions of the 5th–6th c. BC as a territorial term"

⚠ **Correction rule 7 — vocabulary first, translation second.** Use the source's own term (*jana*, *janapada*, *gana*, *sangha*, *chakravarti*, *varna*, *jati*), then gloss it, and flag the gloss as a gloss.

⚠ **Correction rule 8 — the same-word test.** The survival of a **word** is not evidence of the survival of an **institution**. This single rule prevents most false-continuity claims.

IV.5 Error family 5 — Overclaiming from archaeology and aDNA

⚠ **Diagnostic:** you answered Q16, Q19, Q25, Q30 or Q32 wrongly.

Drill R-5 — for each claim, state whether the evidence licenses it, and if not, what would

Claim	Licensed?	What would be needed
"Radiocarbon dating has fixed the age of this civilisation"	✗ No	A stated sample, its stratigraphic context and association, a calibrated range with a standard deviation, and an argument connecting the context to the cultural phase
"aDNA shows this population spoke language X"	✗ No, and never	Nothing. Language is learned; it is not biologically encoded
"aDNA shows admixture between two ancestral components"	✓ Yes, for the sampled individuals	Explicit statement of sample size, preservation bias and the archaeological context of the individuals
"Soil chemistry shows animals were tied in courtyards"	✓ Yes	The stated chain: excreta decomposition raises nitrogen; courtyard soil exceeded interior soil
"The wide distribution of this ware shows a single kingdom"	✗ No	Independent evidence — inscriptions, administrative finds — since an archaeological culture need not correspond to a political unit
"The excavation has rewritten history"	✗ No	Results, publication and scrutiny; only then does a claim enter historiography
"Remote sensing has revealed a buried city"	⚠ Partly	Remote sensing identifies anomalies and potential ; function and chronology require ground-truthing
"Marine fish bones inland show contact with coastal communities"	✓ Yes	Secure identification of species and of the context, plus the distance — at Inamgaon, at least 200 km

⚠ **Correction rule 9 — the licensing question.** For every scientific result, ask what **question the technique answers** and whether your sentence stays inside it.

⚠ **Correction rule 10 — the seven-stage test.** Locate any news item on the cycle permission → fieldwork → transfer/lab → results → publication → scrutiny → historiography. If it sits at stages one to three, no conclusion about the past follows.

IV.6 Error family 6 — Fact-versus-interpretation confusion

⚠ **Diagnostic:** you answered Q24 wrongly, or your practice answers assert without attributing.

Drill R-6 — classify each statement as ✓ fact, ⚠ interpretation, or ? unverifiable

Statement	Class
" <i>Early History of India</i> was published in 1904."	✓ Fact
"Smith's approach was pro-imperialist."	✓ Fact — as stated by R.S. Sharma , and attributable as such
"Colonial historiography was designed to justify British rule."	⚠ Interpretation — well supported, and Sharma argues it explicitly, but it is an argument about function
"R.C. Majumdar was a leading historian of the Nationalist school."	✓ Fact — stated in both authored files and by Upinder Singh
"Nationalist historiography was communal."	⚠ Interpretation, and an unsafe one — assess scholar by scholar
"From the 1950s, left-oriented historians became influential."	✓ Fact

Statement	Class
"Marxist historiography ignored culture."	⚠ Interpretation, and false as stated — the programme studies culture through material contexts; the execution to the 1980s often reduced it
"The 2026 Rakhigarhi analysis showed X."	? Unverifiable — no results exist
"Keeladi proves the antiquity of urban life in Tamil Nadu."	? Contested; the report and its official review were not read by this session
"An archaeological culture need not correspond to a linguistic group."	✓ Fact — a stated methodological principle

⚠ **Correction rule 11 — attribute every interpretation.** "Sharma argues...", "Upinder Singh holds...", "on the materialist reading...". Attribution costs three words and converts an assertion into scholarship.

⚠ **Correction rule 12 — the ? is a mark-earner.** Writing "this remains contested and the evidence is not available to settle it" demonstrates judgement. Inventing a resolution demonstrates the opposite.

PART V — TEN ORIGINAL SOLVED MAINS QUESTIONS

⚠ **Distribution as required: 3 × 10 marks (150 words), 4 × 15 marks (250 words), 3 × 20 marks (300–350 words).** Each carries demand decoding, a full model answer at the highest standard, and a top-answer checklist stating what an outstanding answer for that specific question must contain.

V.A — 10 marks · 150 words

O-1 (10 marks, 150 words)

"Ancient Indian history is the history of how people made a living, not merely of who ruled them." **Examine.**

⚠ **Demand decoding.** "Examine" = inspect the parts and their relations, then state where the proposition holds and where it overreaches. The proposition contains a concealed "not merely", so a wholesale endorsement misreads it: the task is to show that subsistence is **foundational**, without pretending that polity is irrelevant.

Model answer.

The proposition is well founded, provided its concessive clause is respected.

*R.S. Sharma's account of ancient India opens not with a king but with a sequence: how, when and where the earliest cultures developed; how people took to agriculture and stock-raising, which "made life secure and settled"; how they discovered and used natural resources and created the means of livelihood; how they took to farming, spinning, weaving and metalworking, cleared forests, founded villages and cities, and **eventually** large kingdoms. Kingdoms appear last, and as a consequence.*

The analytical gain is causal. Technology enables agriculture; agriculture yields surplus; surplus supports specialists and hierarchy; hierarchy requires an apparatus to protect and legitimise it. Varna, which developed in north India and spread widely, is intelligible as a historical process only within that sequence.

*The clause matters, however: states are not epiphenomena. They reorganise land, extract, standardise and legitimise. **Examined properly: subsistence is foundational, polity consequential — and both are causal.***

Top-answer checklist.

- ✓ Respect the "**not merely**" — do not argue that polity is unimportant.
- ✓ Reproduce **Sharma's own sequence**, with kingdoms in last position.
- ✓ State the **causal chain** explicitly: technology → agriculture → surplus → hierarchy → state.
- ✓ Use **varna** as the worked instance of an institution made intelligible by the chain.
- ✓ Concede that the state is **causally active**, not merely a product.

6. ✓ A verdict that grades both halves rather than choosing one.

O-2 (10 marks, 150 words)

Distinguish between prehistory, protohistory and history in the Indian context, and explain why the boundary between them is not fixed.

⚠ **Demand decoding.** Two tasks: a **definitional** one and an **explanatory** one. The second carries the marks, because the first is available from any textbook.

Model answer.

***Prehistory** is the long period before the invention of writing, and its study. **History** is the part of the past after the invention of writing, and the study of literate societies. **Protohistory** occupies the space between, and in Indian usage it carries several senses: societies without writing that are mentioned in the records of a contemporary literate group; the **Harappan** civilization, literate but with an **undeciphered** script; the period c. 1500–500 BCE, which has an orally transmitted literature but no evidence of writing; and, in archaeologists' usage, the span from the beginning of food production to the advent of iron, covering neolithic and chalcolithic cultures.*

*The boundary moves because it is a statement about **our evidence**, not about the past. The historical period begins in north India in the fourth century BCE; in south India it was placed in the third or second centuries BCE, but evidence from Anuradhapura, Kodumanal and Keezhadi pushes it back to at least the fourth. Decipherment of the Harappan script would move the northern boundary to the third millennium BCE or earlier.*

Top-answer checklist.

1. ✓ Three definitions given **crisply**, in a single sentence each.
2. ✓ **All four** Indian usages of protohistory, since giving one is the standard incomplete answer.
3. ✓ The controlling insight stated in terms: the boundary is a statement about **evidence**.
4. ✓ The **north/south asymmetry**, with the three named sites.
5. ✓ The **decipherment hypothetical**, which proves the point decisively.
6. ⚠ **Optional edge:** note that literacy is a **source condition**, not a grade of civilisation.

O-3 (10 marks, 150 words)

"Provenance is an evidential question before it is a legal one." Comment with reference to the repatriation of Indian antiquities.

⚠ **Demand decoding.** "Comment" wants a **pointed judgement**, stated early. The proposition is a distinction, so the answer must **keep two things apart** and then show why the order matters.

Model answer.

The proposition is correct, and the order it asserts is the reason the argument is strong.

***Provenance** asks where an object has been, from creation to the present, and how we know — a question of documentation, publication, photographs, findspot records and scholarly identification. **Ownership** asks who is legally entitled to hold it, and is settled by statute, treaty and judicial process. The 2026 Australian case separates them cleanly: an independent provenance review by a former High Court judge found significant shortcomings and concluded that ownership histories did not establish lawful export from India, while the return itself proceeds under a Mutual Legal Assistance Treaty following criminal investigation.*

*The evidential priority is decisive for a historian. Archaeological interpretation depends on provenance, stratigraphy, association and recovery method; an object without secure findspot and association loses most of its historical value. Identification of repatriated bronzes to named temples, districts and reigns therefore **restores evidence, not merely property**. That is why the case is strongest when argued evidentially.*

Top-answer checklist.

1. ✓ The two definitions given **separately and precisely**.
2. ✓ A **verified case** with its institutional machinery named — independent provenance review; MLAT; investigating agency.
3. ✓ The link to the **four context conditions** of archaeological interpretation.

4. ✓ The claim that repatriation can be an **epistemic gain**, with the temple-and-reign identifications as evidence.
5. ✓ A verdict that endorses the **order** asserted in the proposition.
6. ⚠ **Optional edge:** distinguish colonial-era acquisition from post-independence trafficking, since they raise different questions.

V.B — 15 marks · 250 words

O-4 (15 marks, 250 words)

"Colonial historiography of ancient India was simultaneously a scholarly achievement and an instrument of rule." Critically examine.

⚠ **Demand decoding.** "Critically examine" = take the claim apart and deliver a judgement **with stated criteria**. The word "simultaneously" forbids choosing a side; the answer must sustain both ledgers and then say how they relate.

Model answer.

Both halves are demonstrable, and the interesting question is how they coexisted.

The achievement is institutional and technical. The Asiatic Society of Bengal was founded at Calcutta in 1784 by Sir William Jones, providing an institutional focus for textual study, epigraphy, numismatics and history; the Bombay Asiatic Society followed in 1804 and the Asiatic Society of Great Britain in 1823, with Sanskrit chairs established across Europe in the first half of the nineteenth century. Jones first proposed that Sanskrit, Latin and Greek belonged to one language family. The nineteenth century produced the decipherment of Ashokan Brahmi and Kharoshthi, a coin-based framework of political chronology, the beginnings of Indian prehistory through Geological Survey officers, and the Archaeological Survey of India in 1871. The discipline still uses these tools.

The instrumentality is equally documented. Research began in the later eighteenth century to serve administrative needs — the Manu Smriti was translated in 1776 as A Code of Gentoo Laws to administer inheritance. After 1857 Britain needed deeper knowledge of a people it ruled, and missionaries sought religious vulnerabilities; the fifty-volume Sacred Books of the East met both. The generalisations that followed — no sense of chronology, habitual despotism, otherworldliness, no experience of self-government — were, in Sharma's judgement, "by and large either false or grossly exaggerated" and served as "good propaganda material", their common purpose being "to demonstrate that Indians were incapable of governing themselves."

Criterion and verdict. Judged by evidential rigour, the **techniques** survive scrutiny and the **generalisations** do not. They coexisted because the same institutions produced both, and Indian informants who supplied much of the material went unacknowledged. Colonial historiography must therefore be **used** and **audited** at once.

Top-answer checklist.

1. ✓ Two separately-headed ledgers, each with **dated, named specifics** — at least four institutions or techniques on one side, at least three commissioning moments on the other.
2. ✓ The four generalisations, and **Sharma's verdict on them quoted or closely paraphrased**.
3. ✓ The **function** argument stated as function, not as motive-reading.
4. ✓ The **uncredited Indian informants**, which is what makes the achievement column itself a historiographical observation.
5. ✓ An explicitly **stated criterion** before the verdict — this is what "critically" requires.
6. ✓ An explanation of **why** the two coexisted, not merely the assertion that they did.
7. ⚠ **Optional edge:** distinguish Mill's armchair periodisation from the Orientalists' collection and translation work, and note that the Orientalists were not homogeneous.

O-5 (15 marks, 250 words)

"Nationalist historiography corrected colonial contempt but retained the colonial frame." Critically examine.

⚠ **Demand decoding.** The proposition has two clauses; both must be evidenced, and the second is the sharper. "Critically" requires a criterion and a verdict, and this topic requires that the verdict be non-partisan.

Model answer.

Both clauses hold, and the second explains the school's long afterlife.

The correction was real and methodological. Nationalist historians wove together texts, inscriptions, coins and material remains to build a connected narrative; they made important contributions to political history, brought south India into it, and advanced the study of regional polities. Specific claims were answered with specific evidence: K.P. Jayswal's articles of 1910–12 and *Hindu Polity* (1924) showed that republics existed and enjoyed a measure of self-government, exploding the myth of Indian despotism; against Smith's allocation of a third of his book to Alexander, Indian scholars emphasised Porus's dialogue and Chandragupta's recovery of the north-west from Seleucus. Research also served reform: Mitra argued from evidence that people ate beef in ancient times; R.G. Bhandarkar reconstructed Satavahana history while advocating widow remarriage; Kane made the *Dharmashastra* an instrument for studying social process.

The frame, however, was retained. The Hindu–Muslim–British periodisation was kept, and it "coalesced with a communal tendency to valorize the 'Hindu period'" and to project the advent of the Turks as a calamity. Golden ages were sought in the Vedas and the Guptas; indigenous roots were insisted upon for all major developments; and until 1960 the field remained political, dynastic and elite.

Criterion and verdict. Judged by method rather than by label, the school must be assessed scholar by scholar: it was neither uniformly communal nor free of tendencies a communal reading could exploit, and the **retained periodisation is the precise mechanism** by which the second became possible. Its evidential achievements survive; its frame did not deserve to.

Top-answer checklist.

1. ✓ **Both** clauses evidenced, with the correction given real weight — an answer that only criticises misreads the proposition.
2. ✓ At least **three named scholars with dated works** on the correction side.
3. ✓ The **proportion-reversal** on Alexander, which is the sharpest single illustration.
4. ✓ **Research-as-reform** instances, which block the nationalist = revivalist equation.
5. ✓ The retained periodisation quoted with its consequence ("coalesced with a communal tendency").
6. ✓ The golden-age, indigenist, political and elite limits, all four.
7. ✓ A **non-partisan verdict** that names the **mechanism** rather than assigning blame.

O-6 (15 marks, 250 words)

Assess the contribution of the materialist approach to the writing of ancient Indian history, and examine the principal criticisms it has attracted.

△ **Demand decoding.** Two directives in one stem — "**assess**" the contribution (graded verdict) and "**examine**" the criticisms (take them apart). Equal weight is wrong: contribution and criticism each need roughly 40% with 20% for a synthesis.

Model answer.

Contribution. The turn began before Marxism: A.L. Basham's *The Wonder That Was India* (1951) marked a great shift from political to non-political history. D.D. Kosambi's *An Introduction to the Study of Indian History* (1957), popularised in *The Civilisation of Ancient India in Historical Outline* (1965), supplied the method — a materialist interpretation derived from Marx, presenting society, economy **and culture** as integral to the development of the forces and relations of production, and offering the first survey volume to show stages of social and economic development in terms of **tribal and class processes**. R.S. Sharma built material culture, production, class, land, varna and state formation into a full account.

Four achievements followed: focus shifted from dynastic history to social and economic structures and processes; modes of production, class stratification and agrarian relations acquired importance; the search for golden ages was replaced by a critical approach acknowledging tensions and conflicts; and there was a concerted attempt to democratize history by recovering the lives of ordinary people.

Criticisms. Up to around the 1980s: unilinear models derived from Western historical and anthropological writings; texts sometimes read uncritically, with insufficient attention to problematic chronology and genre; archaeological data included, yet the framework remained text-centric; and religion and culture often sidelined or mechanically presented as reflections of socio-economic structures.

Verdict. The approach changed the **subject** of ancient Indian history and restored causation to it. Its programme did not exclude culture; its execution frequently reduced it. The criticisms are of implementation, not of the decision to study production and social structure — and two of them, uncritical text-reading and text-centrism, are weaknesses of the **archive** that colonial scholarship shared.

Top-answer checklist.

1. ✓ **Basham first**, so the turn is not falsely dated to Kosambi.
2. ✓ Kosambi's **two works with years** and the exact phrase "tribal and class processes".
3. ✓ All **four** achievements.
4. ✓ All **four** criticisms, stated accurately rather than as caricatures.
5. ✓ The **programme/execution** distinction, which resolves the "ignored culture" charge without evasion.
6. ✓ The observation that two criticisms are **archive** weaknesses shared with colonial scholarship — the mark of genuine reading.
7. ✓ A graded verdict that separates the **decision** to study production from the **manner** of doing so.

O-7 (15 marks, 250 words)

"Every source is also a bias." Examine with reference to texts, inscriptions and archaeology in the reconstruction of ancient India.

⚠ **Demand decoding.** The proposition is a slogan, and the examiner is testing whether the candidate can convert it into method rather than repeating it. The high-scoring move is to show that bias is **informative**.

Model answer.

*The proposition is true and, taken alone, useless. Its value appears only when bias is treated as a **coordinate** rather than a verdict.*

Texts. Ancient texts largely reflect the perspectives of political, social or religious elites; almost all were written by upper-class men for other upper-class men. They are also layered, since composition sometimes ran for centuries, and often normative, presenting an ideal rather than describing practice. A text therefore offers a complex representation and a **refracted** image, not a reflection. But the bias locates the author, which is information: a prescription is excellent evidence for the concerns of those who prescribed.

Inscriptions. They are closer to administration and to datable events, and formulaic and elite-heavy in equal measure. A royal inscription is weak evidence for popular opinion and strong evidence for how power wished to be seen — that is, for legitimization, which is itself a historical fact. Note that UPSC's own 2025 stem reads "Ashokan inscriptions **suggest**".

Archaeology. It escapes the literacy filter and yields an anonymous history of processes rather than events, but it is not neutral: interpretation operates from the classification of an artefact upward, and it depends on provenance, stratigraphy, association and recovery method. Excavation is also selective in what it seeks and finds.

Method, therefore, not despair. Read against the grain, attend to silences, and **co-relate** across independent classes — remembering that integration is not always smooth and that the oral, personal and emotional remain dimly visible. **Bias is where the author was standing; knowing that is evidence.**

Top-answer checklist.

1. ✓ Reject the slogan's uselessness in the opening move — this is what "examine" rewards.
2. ✓ Three source classes, each with its **specific** bias mechanism, not a generic complaint.
3. ✓ For each class, a statement of what its bias makes it **good** evidence for.
4. ✓ The **refraction** metaphor used precisely.
5. ✓ The **co-relation** rule, with its stated limits.
6. ✓ A closing formulation that converts bias into information.
7. ⚠ **Optional edge:** cite UPSC's own use of "suggest" as evidence that the co-relation register is the expected one.

V.C — 20 marks · 300–350 words

O-8 (20 marks, 300–350 words)

"Historiography is the archaeology of interpretations." Critically examine the writing of ancient Indian history from the colonial period to the present.

⚠ **Demand decoding.** A metaphor plus a survey plus "critically". The answer must **unpack the metaphor**, use it as the organising device, survey four phases with dated specifics, and then **test the metaphor's limits** — because a critical examination of a metaphor includes asking where it fails.

Model answer.

The metaphor is apt in three respects and misleading in one, and both matter.

Why it works. Interpretations, like deposits, are laid down in datable contexts; each layer is shaped by the conditions of its formation; and the historian's task is to expose them without confusing one layer for another.

The colonial layer was laid down by governance. Research began in the later eighteenth century to serve administration — the Manu Smriti was translated in 1776 as A Code of Gentoo Laws — and it produced both durable tools and imperial generalisations. The Asiatic Society of Bengal (1784), the decipherment of Ashokan Brahmi and Kharoshthi, coin-based political chronology and the Archaeological Survey of India (1871) remain in use. So, for a time, did the claims that Indians lacked chronology, were accustomed to despotism and had never known self-government — claims whose common purpose, on Sharma's reading, was "to demonstrate that Indians were incapable of governing themselves". V.A. Smith's *Early History of India* (1904) gave the layer its narrative form.

The nationalist layer reversed the verdict without removing the frame. Jayaswal's *Hindu Polity* (1924) established that republics existed and enjoyed a measure of self-government; texts, inscriptions, coins and material remains were woven together; south India entered the narrative. Yet the Hindu–Muslim–British periodisation was retained, golden ages were sought in the Vedas and the Guptas, and the field remained political and elite until 1960.

The materialist layer changed the subject. Basham's 1951 volume shifted attention from political to non-political history; Kosambi's *Introduction* (1957) applied a materialist interpretation derived from Marx and first presented social and economic stages in terms of tribal and class processes; R.S. Sharma built production, class, land and varna into the account, replacing golden ages with tensions and conflicts and attempting to democratize history.

The interdisciplinary layer specified the standard of proof — archaeological science, gender, region, environment, and the reading of texts as discourses shaped by time, genre, authorial perspective and audience.

Where the metaphor fails. Strata are neatly successive; interpretations are not. There was considerable variety within schools, they co-existed in dialogue or conflict, and many writings do not fit the dominant trend of their time — Basham and Kosambi disagreed within six years, while dynastic history still dominated. **Critically examined: historiography is stratified in its formation and entangled in its persistence.**

Top-answer checklist.

- ✓ **Unpack the metaphor** before using it — three respects in which it holds.
- ✓ Four layers, each with **at least two dated, named specifics**.
- ✓ For the colonial layer, **both** the tools and the generalisations.
- ✓ For the nationalist layer, the **verdict reversed / frame retained** formulation.
- ✓ For the materialist layer, the **change of subject**, not merely of opinion.
- ✓ For the interdisciplinary layer, the **standard of proof** framing rather than a technique list.
- ✓ **Test the metaphor's limit**, using the variety-within-schools and co-existence point, with a concrete instance.
- ✓ A closing formulation that keeps both halves — stratified in formation, entangled in persistence.

O-9 (20 marks, 300–350 words)

Critically assess James Mill's periodisation of Indian history in the light of interdisciplinary ancient-history writing.

⚠ **Demand decoding.** "Critically assess" plus a specified vantage point — "in the light of interdisciplinary writing". The answer must therefore not merely refute Mill on internal grounds but show what the newer scholarship **substitutes**,

which is where most answers stop short.

Model answer.

Mill's division of the Indian past into Hindu, Muslim and British periods fails on four independent grounds, and the interdisciplinary turn has replaced it with something better rather than merely rejecting it.

The logical ground is decisive and comes first. The criterion changes midstream: the first two periods are named for religions, the third for a nationality. Why the British and not the Christian period? A classification that switches criteria is not a classification but a narrative — two religious ages followed by a modernising imperial one.

The descriptive ground. The scheme misdescribes its own periods: it cannot accommodate polities ruled by non-Muslim elites after the advent of Turkish rule, and it makes the religion of a tiny ruling stratum the name of an era.

The conceptual ground. The category "Hindu" is anachronistic as a religious identity for much of the span. The term first appears in Iranian inscriptions of the fifth–sixth centuries BC, derived from Sindhu, denoting a district on the Indus — a territorial unit, "neither a religion nor a community". R.S. Sharma adds that neither Hindu nor Hindu dharma is known to any ancient Sanskrit or other ancient source. The scheme also erases the periods and regions in which Buddhism and Jainism flourished.

The political ground. The division helped project Islam as a fundamental fracture in Indian society; it took root in the colonial period and was **retained** by nationalist historians, where it coalesced with a tendency to valorize the "Hindu period".

What replaced it. Most historians adopted a more neutral fourfold classification — ancient/early to the sixth century CE, early medieval to the twelfth or thirteenth, medieval to the eighteenth, modern thereafter — while insisting that the dividing lines may vary and that these are not hard lines. Interdisciplinary work then supplied the positive alternative: periods defined by **processes** — urbanisation, state formation, agrarian expansion, exchange, social form and cultural change — cross-cut by an evidence-based axis of prehistory, protohistory and history, whose boundaries have themselves moved with new epigraphic evidence.

Assessment: Mill's scheme is not an outdated tool but an incoherent one, and its replacement is not a better label but a different **kind** of question.

Top-answer checklist.

1. ✓ Four grounds, **separately headed**, with the logical one first.
2. ✓ The **criterion-switch** stated as the decisive objection.
3. ✓ The **etymological evidence** on *Hindu*, with the date and the meaning.
4. ✓ Sharma's **attestation** point on *Hindu dharma*.
5. ✓ The **erasure** of Buddhism and Jainism.
6. ✓ The political function, with the **retention** by nationalists.
7. ✓ The replacement scheme **with dates and with its self-limiting clause**.
8. ✓ The positive interdisciplinary alternative — **process axis plus evidence axis** — because rejection alone is a half answer.
9. ✓ A closing distinction between a **better label** and a **different kind of question**.

O-10 (20 marks, 300–350 words)

"Scientific techniques have widened the questions historians of ancient India can ask, but have not removed the need for interpretation." Discuss.

⚠ **Demand decoding.** "Discuss" with a two-clause proposition. Both clauses must be evidenced with **specific** techniques and **specific** limits, and the answer must end with a position on how the two relate.

Model answer.

Both clauses are true, and the second is what makes the first useful.

The widening is real and specific. Questions once answerable only by inference are now measurable. Chemical comparison of metal artefacts with ores identifies **ore sources**. Soil chemistry locates activity: at Inamgaon, higher nitrogen in courtyards than in house interiors showed that animals were tied in the courtyards. Faunal analysis

identifies domestication, age at death, draught use through fused joints, season of occupation, and contact — marine fish bones and shells at Inamgaon, at least 200 km from the sea, demonstrate coastal links. Bioarchaeology reads diet from dental structure, deficiency from trace elements and enamel, disease from bone, and — crucially — social inequality from a comparison of nutritional inputs in the bones of men and women. Genome analysis contributes to understanding migration and population change. Remote sensing and GIS identify palaeo-channels, structures, moats and roads non-invasively, which matters most where built-up conditions preclude excavation.

The interpretive requirement is undiminished. Radiocarbon dating supplies approximate dates with a standard deviation, requires calibration, can be corrupted by contamination or procedural error, and dates a **sample** in a **context** — not a civilisation. Which date in a string to highlight, and which end of a bracket to emphasise, are judgements. Ancient DNA yields biological ancestry, relatedness, admixture and migration patterns for the individuals sampled; it cannot identify a language, a caste or a religion, none of which is biologically encoded, and preservation and sampling are uneven. Remote sensing identifies **potential**, not chronology or function. And interpretation is as crucial in archaeology as in textual work — operating, as Upinder Singh notes, from the classification of an artefact upward to the framing of hypotheses.

How the two relate. Technique narrows uncertainty on **specific physical questions** and thereby raises the standard of proof for **historical** ones. Strength now comes from the **convergence of independent method families**, and independence must itself be argued, since techniques applied to the same material for the same claim are not independent. **Science has not replaced the historian; it has raised the price of a careless sentence.**

Top-answer checklist.

1. ✓ At least **five** specific techniques with what each delivers, named concretely.
2. ✓ At least **two named Indian instances** — Inamgaon nitrogen and Inamgaon marine fauna are ideal.
3. ✓ The radiocarbon limits **in full**: approximation, standard deviation, calibration, contamination, and dating a sample in a context.
4. ✓ The **aDNA boundary**, stated as a boundary and not a doubt.
5. ✓ The statement that **interpretation operates from artefact classification upward**.
6. ✓ The **convergence and independence** argument, which is the analytical core.
7. ✓ A closing formulation that positions science as **raising the standard**, not replacing the historian.
8. ⚠ **Optional edge**: one sentence applying the seven-stage claim life cycle to any current excavation news, so the answer is demonstrably 2026-safe.

PART VI — GS-I HISTORY HIGH-SCORE ANSWER PROTOCOL

VI.1 The protocol, in ten rules

- R1 READ THE DIRECTIVE TWICE AND WRITE IT AT THE TOP OF YOUR ROUGH PLAN.
Most lost marks in GS-I History are directive failures, not knowledge failures.
- R2 FIND THE HIDDEN SOURCE-STATUS QUESTION. "Assess the importance of...", "represents one of the most important sources of our knowledge...", "reflect the spirit of the age" -- all three are asking WHAT THIS EVIDENCE CAN DELIVER. Answer that, not the content question.
- R3 OPEN WITH A DISTINCTION OR A CLASSIFICATION, NEVER WITH A DEFINITION COPIED FROM A TEXTBOOK. One sentence that divides the problem earns more than three that describe it.
- R4 ONE DATED, NAMED SPECIFIC PER PARAGRAPH. A year, a work, an institution, a site. Generalities are unmarkable.
- R5 NEVER WRITE "PROVE". Use the ladder: compatible -> consistent -> convergent -> mutually constraining. And use "co-relate".
- R6 CONCEDE THE STRONGEST OBJECTION IN YOUR OWN WORDS BEFORE ANSWERING IT. This is the single highest-yield habit in "critically examine" questions.
- R7 IF YOU CITE A CURRENT ITEM, DATE IT, NAME ITS SOURCE CLASS, AND PLACE IT ON THE CLAIM LIFE CYCLE. Stages 1-3 evidence the DIRECTION of research, never a conclusion about the past.
- R8 ATTRIBUTE EVERY INTERPRETATION. "Sharma argues...", "Upinder Singh holds..." Three words that convert assertion into scholarship.
- R9 END WITH A GRADED VERDICT AND A STATED CRITERION. Not "thus it is important" but "judged by X, it is A to this extent and B beyond it".
- R10 BEFORE SUBMITTING, SCAN FOR THE TEN FORBIDDEN SENTENCES.

VI.2 The ten forbidden sentences

1. ✗ "Archaeology has proved the text."
2. ✗ "DNA has established that they spoke ____."
3. ✗ "Carbon dating has fixed the age of the civilisation."
4. ✗ "The Hindu period was followed by the Muslim period."
5. ✗ "Ancient India was a golden age of ____."
6. ✗ "India remained unchanged for centuries."
7. ✗ "There is no evidence, so it did not exist."
8. ✗ "Nationalist historians simply glorified the past."
9. ✗ "Marxist historians ignored culture."
10. ✗ "The recent excavation has rewritten history."

VI.3 Time allocation, by mark level

Marks	Words	Plan	Write	Verdict	Scan
10	150	1.5 min	4 min	1 min	0.5 min
15	250	2 min	5.5 min	1 min	0.5 min
20	300–350	3 min	8 min	1.5 min	0.5 min

⚠ **The rule that saves papers:** if you are running out of time, cut a **body paragraph**, never the **verdict**. An answer with two dimensions and a verdict scores above an answer with four dimensions and no conclusion.

VI.4 The eight-step spine, restated for use under exam conditions

1 DEFINE + FRAME	one sentence, no more
2 THE PROBLEM	only if the question is method-facing
3 EVIDENCE ARCHITECTURE	source classes in play, and the co-relation rule
4 THE SCHOOLS	"overlapping and contending", never "succeeding"
5 THE TURN WANTED	the deepest paragraph; read the directive to find it
6 BIAS + SILENCE	two or three of the eight distortions
7 CURRENT ANCHOR	one dated, verified item, correctly staged
8 VERDICT	graded, with the criterion stated

PART VII — FINAL RAPID REVISION MATRIX

VII.1 The four schools, in one screen

	Colonial / Orientalist	Nationalist	Marxist / materialist	Interdisciplinary
When	2nd half 18th – early 20th c.	late 19th – first half 20th c.	influential from the 1950s	late 20th c. – present
Context	EIC governance; 1857; missionary purpose	emergent then strong national movement	post-1947 social science	globalised, technology-enabled scholarship
Key names and dates	Mill (H-M-B); Jones 1784 ; Max Mueller 1823–1902 , SBE 50 vols ; Smith 1904	Mitra, R.G. Bhandarkar, Rajwade 22 vols , Kane 5 vols , D.R. Bhandarkar, Raychaudhuri, Majumdar, Jayaswal 1924 , Altekar, Nilakanta Sastri	Basham 1951 ; Kosambi 1957, 1965 ; R.S. Sharma	archaeological science, gender, subaltern, region, environment, digital corpora
Core question	political rule; despotism; foreign impulse	agency; polity; achievement; indigenous roots	forces and relations of production; class; varna; state formation	what does this evidence license ?
Method	collection, editing, translation; epigraphy; numismatics; archaeology	multi-source synthesis: texts + inscriptions + coins + remains	materialist stages; tribal → class processes	co-relation; scientific technique; reading against the grain; discourse analysis
Gain	institutions and techniques still in use — Asiatic Society 1784 , ASI 1871 , decipherment of Brahmi and Kharoshthi	corrected contempt; brought in south India and regional polities	structure over narrative; democratized history; restored causation	new question types; inclusion; measured evidence; regional texture
Limit	pro-imperial generalisation; static society; H-M-B took root; Indian informants uncredited	golden ages; indigenism; elite and political until 1960 ; H-M-B retained	unilinear Western models; texts read uncritically; text-centric ; culture reduced to reflection	technique-worship; overclaiming; fragmentation
In seven words	knowledge built for rule	verdict reversed, frame retained	the subject was changed	the standard of proof was specified

VII.2 The twenty dates that must be automatic

Date	Event
1765	Bengal and Bihar under East India Company rule
1776	<i>Manu Smriti</i> translated as <i>A Code of Gentoo Laws</i>
1784	Asiatic Society of Bengal, Calcutta — Sir William Jones

Date	Event
1785 / 1789	<i>Bhagvadgita</i> (Wilkins) / <i>Abhijnanashakuntalam</i> (Jones)
1804 / 1823	Bombay Asiatic Society / Asiatic Society of Great Britain, London
1857	Revolt — the trigger for deeper colonial knowledge-gathering
1871	Archaeological Survey of India established
1890	Archaeological Survey of Ceylon established
1904	V.A. Smith, <i>Early History of India</i>
1910–12 / 1924	Jayaswal's articles / <i>Hindu Polity</i>
1926	Rajwade's Marathi history of the institution of marriage
1949	Willard Libby discovers radiocarbon dating
1950	The 'BP' baseline year
1951	A.L. Basham, <i>The Wonder That Was India</i>
1954–60	ASI salvage work at Nagarjunakonda
1957 / 1965	Kosambi's <i>Introduction / Civilisation... in Historical Outline</i>
1950s / until 1960	Marxist influence begins / political history still dominant
1960s	New Archaeology and processualism
Since 1980	Sharma's dating of the "Communal Approach"
1871 → 2026	The ASI that granted the 13 March 2026 Keeladi permission is an 1871 creation

VII.3 The chronology traps

✕ Trap	✓ Correction
Harappan and Rig Vedic are contemporaneous	Mature Harappan 2600–1900 BC ; Rig Veda 1500–1000 BC ; overlap only late/post-Harappan; the identity question is unsettled
One date for Kanishka	AD 78 (R.S. Sharma, older association) versus c. AD 127 (Upinder Singh: most scholars), with Kushana and Shaka eras distinct
Brahmi is the oldest script	Harappan is the oldest script ; Brahmi is the oldest deciphered script, from at least the 4th c. BCE
The historical period begins in India in the 4th c. BCE	In north India . South India generally 3rd/2nd c. BCE, pushed back on Anuradhapura, Kodumanal and Keezhadi evidence to at least the 4th c. BCE
The ancient/early-medieval boundary is fixed	6th c. CE on post-Gupta structural change; c. AD 750 on land-grant-based regional kingdoms — criterion-dependent

VII.4 The method one-liners

Concept	One line
<i>historia</i>	Inquiry or investigation — not memory
Historiography	The scholarly activity of constructing and writing history
Three gaps	Survival bias · the historian's present · narrative form

Concept	One line
Four operations	Authenticate and date · contextualise · co-relate · read the silence
Absence rule	Not evidence of absence unless survivability, adequate search and patterned silence are all shown
Texts	Layered, normative, refracted, elite-authored
Archaeology	Anonymous history of processes; not a prehistory-only tool; interpretation-laden
Co-relation ladder	Compatible → consistent → convergent → mutually constraining. Never "proves"
Context conditions	Provenance · stratigraphy · association · recovery method
Radiocarbon	Dates a sample in a context , approximately, with ±, needing calibration
aDNA	Biological ancestry — not language, caste or religion; and for the individuals sampled
Archaeological culture	Not a linguistic group, political unit, lineage, clan or tribe
Periodisation	A label is an argument; test criterion, consistency and what it hides
Provenance vs ownership	Evidential vs legal — and evidential comes first for a historian
Claim life cycle	Permission → fieldwork → transfer → results → publication → scrutiny → historiography
The guard clause	Partial and provisional, but not equally reliable or acceptable

VII.5 The current anchors, correctly staged

Date	Item	Source class	Stage	Safe sentence
13 March 2026 (reported 16 March)	ASI permits TNSDA to excavate 8 Tamil Nadu sites incl. Keeladi phase 11 , under the AMASR Rules, 1959	Reputable-media secondary	1 — permission	"The ASI granted excavation permission on 13 March 2026 for the eleventh phase at Keeladi and seven other sites."
16 March 2026	Gyan Bharatam National Manuscript Survey , Ministry of Culture — geo-tagged national inventory; four stages; voluntary; ownership unaffected	Official (culture.gov.in)	Infrastructure	"The Ministry of Culture launched a geo-tagged national manuscript survey on 16 March 2026, expressly without affecting ownership."
13 May 2026	Return of Chola Shiva Nataraja c. 990 CE , 12th-c. Somaskanda , 16th-c. Sundarar with Paravai from the Smithsonian's National Museum of Asian Art; removed early 1950s ; ASI provenance research ; USA agreed to return 1400+ antiquities	Official (culture.gov.in)	Custody / provenance	"Three bronzes returned from the Smithsonian were acknowledged in New Delhi on 13 May 2026 following ASI provenance research."

Date	Item	Source class	Stage	Safe sentence
22 June 2026	ASI → AnSI transfer of Rakhigarhi skeletal remains under an MoU; 8 burials at Mound No. 7 , 2025–26 season; 3 complete skeletons; AnSI repository and laboratory, Kolkata ; site ~550 ha	Official (newsonair.gov.in)	3 — transfer	"Skeletal material from Rakhigarhi was transferred to AnSI on 22 June 2026 for multidisciplinary analysis; results await publication."
July 2026	Australia to repatriate a bronze Bhadrakali trident , a granite Nandi and a basalt six-headed Karthikeya , 11th–12th c., under the MLAT ; Crennan review found provenance shortcomings; source temples identified at Kollumangudi (Tiruvarur) and Manambadi (Thanjavur) , the latter built under Rajendra Chola I	Reputable-media secondary, quoting the Ministry of Culture	Custody / provenance	"Australia is set to repatriate three eleventh–twelfth-century antiquities under the MLAT, following a provenance review that found ownership histories did not establish lawful export."
17 Dec 2025 → mid-2026	BharatSHRI digitisation of ~76,000 estampages , ASI Directorate of Epigraphy, Mysuru ; 1:1 imaging; weekly uploads with metadata and transcriptional details; Union Budget 2023-24 approval	Reputable-media secondary	Infrastructure	"Digitisation of about 76,000 inscriptional estampages at the ASI's Mysuru epigraphy directorate began in December 2025 under BharatSHRI."

VII.6 The final self-test — ten questions to answer without notes

1. What are the three interrogatives with which R.S. Sharma opens his account of ancient India, and why does the order matter?
2. State the four claims in Upinder Singh's quartet, and identify which one prevents relativism.
3. Name the five objections to the Hindu–Muslim–British periodisation and say which is decisive on logical grounds alone.
4. Give V.A. Smith's dates, his book, its year, and three specific criticisms of it.
5. Name four Nationalist historians with a dated work each, and state the school's four limitations.
6. Give Kosambi's two works with years, his method in one clause, and four criticisms of the school up to the 1980s.
7. State the four Indian usages of protohistory.
8. State the five things ancient DNA licenses and the three it does not.
9. Distinguish provenance from ownership, and say why the distinction matters to a historian rather than only to a lawyer.
10. Recite the seven-stage claim life cycle and identify at which stage almost all heritage news reports sit.

✓ **End of the premium solved workbook.** ⚠ Companion volume:

Importance-Historiography_Complete-Learning-Session_2026-08-10.md — *eleven fully taught subtopics with pre-teach checklists, visuals, facts-and-inferences tables, traps, revision notes, thirty-eight MCQs across eleven mastery loops, a source-coverage ledger proving the integration of both the basic and the advanced authored files, a final validation checklist, and complete consolidated register notes.*